

# Portuguese, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they  
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at  
[code/learning/human-languages/portuguese/lessons/](https://code/learning/human-languages/portuguese/lessons/)

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# Preface

This is the Portuguese volume of a wider project, written for someone starting from zero whose only shared language is English. Portuguese is taught one word at a time, each taken apart — traced to its root (usually Latin), then forward to the English cousins you already own. *obrigado* (“thanks”) turns out to be English *obligated*; *tarde* (“afternoon”) is *tardy*; *noite* (“night”) is the *noct-* of *nocturnal*.

Portuguese is a daughter of Latin, and often the one that wore its words down *most*: the article *ille* eroded all the way to a single letter, *o*. Where a sister language (Spanish, French, Italian) makes a contrast vivid, the book supplies it in full — no prior knowledge of them assumed.

Three things shape every lesson: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of cousins; and the cultural or idiomatic reason a thing is said. Pronunciation is a short reference at the front, never a gate. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.



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# Portuguese pronunciation — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — each lesson gives the sounds its word needs. This page gathers them. Portuguese spelling is fairly regular, but its **nasal vowels** and soft consonants surprise English speakers.

## The traps for an English speaker

- **Nasal vowels.** A vowel before *m/n* (or under a tilde) is sent through the nose: *bom* = *bõ*, *sim* (“yes”) = *sĩ*, *pão* (“bread”) = *pãw*. English has no exact match — hum the vowel.
- **Vowels reduce.** Unstressed *e* often vanishes to a whisper or *i*; final *o* sounds like *u* (*obrigado* ≈ “oh-bree-GAH-doo”).
- **s** between vowels = *z*; at the end of a syllable it is often *sh* (European) or *s* (most of Brazil).
- **lh** = the *lli* of *million*; **nh** = the *ny* of *canyon*; **ç** = *s*.
- **r** at the start of a word, or **rr**, is a strong guttural (like a Scottish/French *r* or even an *h*); a single *r* between vowels is a light tap.

## Stress

Usually the second-to-last syllable; a written accent (*á*, *â*, *ã*) marks any exception (*olá*, *café*, *avô*).

## Portuguese in the Romance family

Portuguese, Spanish, French, and Italian are all worn-down Latin. Portuguese often eroded the most (the article *ille* → *o*); it turned Latin *-ct-* into *-it-* (*noite*, like French *nuit*); and it kept *dies* close (*o dia*, like Spanish *día*). The lessons draw these contrasts as they arise.

## Chapter 1

# Greetings

The Portuguese greetings, built from their pieces — a word for “good,” the day-parts, the article that carries gender, and a “thank you” that changes with *who is speaking*. Each word is taken apart to its root and its English cousins. *Practice lessons: lessons/PT-C01-\*.md.*

### 1.1 *olá* — “hi”

#### Sounds you’ll need

*oh-LAH* — stress on the second syllable (the written accent on *á* marks it). The *l* is clear, the *a* open.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**olá** (“hi”) is a friendly interjection of uncertain birth — probably a natural call for attention (like English *hello* / *hallo*), possibly reinforced by Arabic *w-Allāh* (“by God”) during the centuries of Moorish Iberia. Unlike most Portuguese words, it has *no* clean Latin root: some greetings are just sounds. Spanish, its close sibling, has the near- identical *hola*.

#### Why it’s said this way

*olá* is friendly and fairly neutral — fine for most people, though for real formality or a first meeting you add *bom dia* / *boa tarde*, built next. In Brazil you’ll also hear *oi* for a casual “hi.”

## 1.2 *bom* / *boa* — “good”

### Sounds you’ll need

**bom** is **nasal** — *bõ*, the *m* not fully closed, the vowel sent through the nose. **boa** (feminine) is a clear *BOH-ah*.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**bom** / **boa** (“good”) ← Latin *bonus* / *bona* → English **bonus**, **bonanza**. Spanish, another daughter of Latin, made *bueno* / *buena*; Portuguese wore *bonus* down further, to the little nasal *bom*.

### Grammar Lens

**bom** / **boa** **agrees** with its noun: *bom* (m.), *boa* (f.), *bons* / *boas* (pl.) — Latin’s adjective agreement, alive across the Romance family. So it’s *bom dia* (m.) but *boa tarde* (f.).

## 1.3 *o* / *a* — “the,” and an article worn to a single letter

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**o** (masculine “the”) and **a** (feminine) ← Latin *ille* / *illa* (“that one”). Here Portuguese did something striking: it wore the word down *further than any of its sisters* — Latin *ille* → Italian *il* → Spanish *el* → Portuguese just **o**. The whole demonstrative has eroded to a single vowel. (English “the” is Germanic, unrelated.)

### Grammar Lens

Every Portuguese noun is **masculine or feminine** — Latin’s genders collapsed to two. Learn each noun *with* its article: *o* for masculine, *a* for feminine. Beware the trap coming next: *o dia* (“the day”) is *masculine* even though it ends in *-a*.

## 1.4 *dia* — “day”

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**o dia** (masc.) ← Latin *dies* (“day”) — taken almost straight, like Spanish *dia*. Cousins straight from *dies*: **di**urnal, **di**ary; and, through the derived *diurnum*, English **j**ournal and **j**ourney (which is why Italian *giorno* and French *jour* look so different — they took the longer road).

### Grammar Lens

**A gender trap.** *dia* ends in *-a* — the usual feminine signal — yet it is *masculine*: *o dia*. This is a fossil of its Latin origin (*dies* was masculine), and a reminder to learn each noun *with* its article rather than guessing gender from the ending.

## 1.5 *bom dia* — “good day / good morning,” assembled

*bom* (“good”) + *dia* (“day”) = **bom dia**, “good day” — and, in practice, “good morning”: it’s the greeting until noon.

### Why it’s said this way

*bom dia* is the polite, all-purpose morning hello — safe with anyone. After midday it gives way to *boa tarde*, and after dark to *boa noite*. (Spanish pluralises the blessing — *buenos días* — where Portuguese keeps it singular, *bom dia*.)

## 1.6 *tarde* — “afternoon,” and *boa tarde*

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**a tarde** (fem.) ← Latin *tardus* (“slow, late”) — the same *tardus* behind English **tard**y and **retard** (“to slow”). Portuguese named the afternoon after its *lateness*, exactly as Spanish did with the identical *tarde*. **boa tarde** = “good afternoon.”

## 1.7 *noite* — “night,” and *boa noite*

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**a noite** (fem.) ← Latin *noctem* (*noct-*) → English **nocturnal**, **equinox**. Portuguese turned the Latin *-ct-* into **-it-** (*noite*) — the same change French made (*nuit*), while Spanish went *-ch-* (*noche*) and Italian *-tt-* (*notte*).

| Latin         | Portuguese   | Spanish      | French      | Italian      |
|---------------|--------------|--------------|-------------|--------------|
| <i>noctem</i> | <i>noite</i> | <i>noche</i> | <i>nuit</i> | <i>notte</i> |
| <i>factum</i> | <i>feito</i> | <i>hecho</i> | <i>fait</i> | <i>fatto</i> |

**boa noite** = “good night” — used both as an evening greeting and as the farewell for bed.

## 1.8 *obrigado* / *obrigada* — “thank you,” i.e. “[I am] obliged”

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**obrigado** / **obrigada** (“thanks”) ← Latin *obligātus* (“bound, obliged”), from *ob-* (“to”) + *ligāre* (“to bind”). It is the *same* word as English **obligated**, and shares its root with **oblige**, **obligation**, and (via *ligare*) **ligament** and **liable**. To say *obrigado* is to say “I am *bound* to you” — indebted by your kindness.

### Grammar Lens

**It agrees with the speaker, not the listener.** Because *obrigado* literally means “[I am] obliged,” it takes the gender of *whoever is speaking*: a man says **obrigado**, a woman says **obrigada** — no matter who they’re thanking. This is unlike the other tracks’ adjectives (which match the noun); here the adjective matches *you*.

## 1.9 The day of greetings

| Portuguese                 | English        |
|----------------------------|----------------|
| <i>olá</i>                 | hi             |
| <i>bom dia</i>             | good morning   |
| <i>boa tarde</i>           | good afternoon |
| <i>boa noite</i>           | good night     |
| <i>obrigado / obrigada</i> | thank you      |

Every piece traced: *bom* (*bonus*), *dia* (*dies*), *tarde* (*tardus*, “late”; English *tardy*), *noite* (*noctem*, -ct-→-it-), *obrigado* (*obligātus*, “obliged”). And two Portuguese habits: the article eroded to a single vowel (*o* / *a*), and “thank you” agrees with the *speaker* (*obrigado* / *obrigada*). Next chapter: introducing yourself — *o meu nome é...* / *chamo-me...* — and Portuguese’s *tu* vs. *você* (familiar / polite “you”).





## Chapter 2

# How Are You?

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 2.1 de nada — "you're welcome," or "it was nothing"

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] You already say **obrigado** / **obrigada** ("I am obliged"). The reply that closes the exchange is **de nada** — "of nothing" — the very same phrase, word for word, as Spanish.

#### Sounds you'll need

- **final-a-reduces** — **de nada**  $\approx$  *dee NAH-duh*: unstressed final *-a* softens toward *uh*; the *d* is soft.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **de** = "of / from" (Latin **dē**).
- **nada** = "nothing" — and it has the same buried story as its Spanish twin.

**nada** comes from Latin (**rēs**) **nāta**, "*a born thing*" — from *nāscī*, "to be born" (English **native**, **nature**, **natal**, re-**nais-sance**). Latin *nōn ... rēs nāta*, "not a single born thing," wore down until the "born thing" word, **nada**, came to mean **nothing** by itself.

Portuguese and Spanish inherited the identical word and the identical

courtesy:

| language   | "you're welcome" | the "nothing" word                         |
|------------|------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Portuguese | <i>de nada</i>   | <i>nada</i> ← <i>nāta</i> , "a born thing" |
| Spanish    | <i>de nada</i>   | <i>nada</i> ← <i>nāta</i> , "a born thing" |
| French     | <i>de rien</i>   | <i>rien</i> ← <i>rem</i> , "a thing"       |

So Iberia says "of no *born-thing*"; France says "of no *thing*." Same shrug of the shoulders, one Latin idea.

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "obrigado / obrigada" ... "de nada" — the full exchange]
- [YOU SAY: "de nada" then English "native, nature" — *nada*'s true family]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What did *nada* originally mean in Latin? (A *born thing* — *nāta*.) Which language shares *de nada* exactly, and which uses *de rien* instead? (Spanish; French.) Next: **como**, "how."

## 2.2 como — "how," the fourth *quomodo* cousin

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] One of two everyday ways to ask *how are you?* in Portuguese starts with **como**, "how." It's the same word you've met (or will meet) across the Romance family.

### Sounds you'll need

- **final-o-is-u** — **como** = *KOH-moo*: the final unstressed *-o* is said like *u*. (Portuguese does this to nearly every final *-o*: *obrigado* → *-doo*.)

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**como** = "how / like / as." Root: Latin **quōmodo**, "in what manner" — *quō* ("in what way") + *modo* ("manner"). It is the **same source** as its siblings:

- Spanish **cómo**, Italian **come**, French **comment** — all "how."
- Doubling as "like/as," it matches Spanish *como*, Italian *come*.

Notice Portuguese and Spanish look almost identical here — *como* vs *cómo* — the only visible difference is the Spanish written accent that marks the *question*. Portuguese leans on context and the question mark instead. The *modo* piece lives on in English **mode**, **model**, **moderate**.

### Grammar Lens: the two Portuguese "how are you"s

Portuguese asks after you **two** ways, and you'll assemble both next lesson:

- **Como vai?** — "how do you **go**?" (verb *ir*, "to go" — like French/German).
- **Como está?** — "how do you **stand/are**?" (verb *estar* — like Spanish).

Plus a third, verb-free favourite — **Tudo bem?** — coming up.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "como" — *KOH-moo*]
- [YOU SAY: *como* / *cómo* / *come* / *comment* — the four *quomodo* siblings]
- [YOU SAY: "Como vai?" and "Como está?" — go, and stand]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What Latin word gives *como*, and name two siblings. (*quōmodo* → *cómo*, *come*, *comment*.) What's the only written dif-

ference between Portuguese *como* and Spanish *cómo*? (The Spanish accent that marks a question.) Next: the word behind Portuguese's favourite greeting — **tudo**.

## 2.3 tudo — "everything," the heart of *Tudo bem?*

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] The most Brazilian way to greet someone doesn't use a "you" or a "to be" at all — it just asks **Tudo bem?**, "everything well?" To own it, learn its first word: **tudo**, "everything."

### Sounds you'll need

- final-o-is-u — **tudo** = *TOO-doo*: final -o → u, and the d is soft.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**tudo** = "everything, all," from Latin **tōtus**, "*whole, entire*." You ask whether the **whole** of someone's life is going well — *is everything OK?* That root **tōtus** is completely at home in English:

- **total, totally, totality** — the whole amount.
- **teetotal** — "**totally**" abstaining (a playful reduplication of *total*).
- Italian **tutto**, Spanish **todo**, French **tout** — the same *tōtus* across the family (you'll hear Spanish *todo* echoing this).

### Grammar Lens: pairing it with "well"

Portuguese "well" is **bem** (← Latin *bene*, "well" — the *bene* of *benefit*, *benevolent*; cousin of Spanish *bien*, French *bien*). Put them together:

**Tudo bem?** = "Everything well?" → "How are you? / You OK?"

The magic: **no pronoun, no verb**. You skip the whole *ocê / tu / o senhor* tangle. That's why *Tudo bem?* is the friendliest, safest opener in Brazilian Portuguese — and you can answer with the very same two

words: **Tudo bem.** (“Everything’s well.”) Or just **Tudo bom.**

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “tudo” — *TOO-doo*]
- [YOU SAY: “Tudo bem?” — everything well?]
- [YOU SAY: “tudo” then English “total, totally” — one family]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What Latin word gives *tudo*, and its English cousins? (*tōtus* → total, totally, teetotal.) Why is *Tudo bem?* so easy to use? (No pronoun, no verb — it dodges the *você/tu/senhora* choice.) What’s Portuguese for “well”? (*bem* ← *bene*.) Next: assemble all three “how are you”s.

## 2.4 Tudo bem? — “everything well?”

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] You know **tudo**, “everything.” Add **bem**, “well,” and Portuguese gives you an everyday check-in with no verb at all.

**Tudo bem?** — “Everything well?” / “How are you?”

The friendly answer can be identical:

**Tudo bem.** — “Everything’s well.”

Because the question contains no “you” and no verb, it avoids choosing a social register. That simplicity is exactly why it is everywhere.

#### Grammar Lens: Add the listener only when useful

To bounce the question back, say:

**Tudo bem, e você?** — “All well, and you?”

Everyday **você** comes from *vossa mercê*, “your mercy.” Centuries of fast speech wore a respectful title into the ordinary pronoun “you,” much as Spanish *usted* grew from a form meaning “your grace.” For more explicit respect, Portuguese can use **o senhor** / **a senhora**, “the gentleman / the lady.”

You do not need either pronoun for the basic pair: **Tudo bem?** — **Tudo bem.**

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “Tudo bem?”]
- [YOU SAY: the answer — “Tudo bem.”]
- [YOU SAY: “Tudo bem, e você?”]

[REPEAT x2] “Tudo bem? — Tudo bem!”

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does *Tudo bem?* literally ask? (“Everything well?”) Why can it fit almost any listener? (It has **no verb and no pronoun.**) How do you bounce it back? (**E você?**) Where did *você* come from? (*Vossa mercê*, “your mercy.”) Next: two questions that do use verbs.

## 2.5 Como vai? / Como está? — go and stand

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] **Tudo bem?** needs no verb. **Como** (“how”) also builds two familiar metaphors.

| question          | literally                   | verb                         |
|-------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------|
| <b>Como vai?</b>  | “How does it <b>go</b> ?”   | <i>ir</i> , to go            |
| <b>Como está?</b> | “How do you <b>stand</b> ?” | <i>estar</i> , to be / stand |

**Vai** comes from *ir*, whose Latin ancestor *īre* also sits inside English *exit* and *transit*. **Está** comes from Latin *stāre*, “to stand.”

Portuguese therefore keeps both pictures:

- the “go” family, like French and German;
- the “stand” family, like Spanish and Italian.

Italian also keeps both. You do not need those languages to speak Portuguese; the map simply makes the two metaphors memorable.

**Tudo bem?** remains the easiest default because it skips the verb and register choice altogether.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: the verb-free question — “Tudo bem?”]
- [YOU SAY: the “go” question — “Como vai?”]
- [YOU SAY: the “stand” question — “Como está?”]

[REPEAT x2] “Tudo bem? — Como vai? — Como está?”

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which question has no verb? (**Tudo bem?**) Which uses “go”? (**Como vai?**, from *ir*.) Which uses “stand”? (**Como está?**, from *estar*.) Portuguese keeps how many metaphors? (**Both.**) Next: the “more or less” answer.

## 2.6 mais ou menos — the “more or less” shrug

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Someone asks *Tudo bem?* You’re okay-ish. The Portuguese shrug is **mais ou menos** — “more or less” — the same words, root for root, that Spanish uses.

#### Sounds you’ll need

- **nasal-ai** — **mais**  $\approx$  *mais* with a nasal glide (*maish* in Brazil, the *s* a soft *sh*).
- **final-o-is-u** — **menos**  $\approx$  *MEH-noos*; **ou** = a closed *oh*.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**mais ou menos** = literally **"more or less."** Every piece is Latin at heart:

- **mais** = "more," from Latin **magis** ("more") — cousin of *major*, *master*, *maximum*, *mayor*.
- **ou** = "or," from Latin **aut**.
- **menos** = "less," from Latin **minus** — the very word English borrowed for *minus*, *minor*, *minimum*, *minuscule*.

So *mais ou menos* is a **word-for-word twin of Spanish *más o menos*** — Iberia's shared shrug. (Portuguese *mais* and Spanish *más* are the same *magis*; the nasal *-ais* is just Portuguese's accent.)

### Grammar Lens: your answer ladder for *Tudo bem?*

| answer                                  | sense                 |
|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| <b>Tudo bem / Tudo ótimo</b>            | all well / all great  |
| <b>Mais ou menos</b>                    | so-so                 |
| <b>Mais ou menos + a</b><br>hand-wobble | "eh, could be better" |

The five-language shrug set is now complete: Portuguese/Spanish **mais/más o menos** ("more or less"), Italian **così così** ("so, so"), French **comme ci comme ça** ("like this, like that"), German **es geht** ("it goes").

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "mais ou menos" — with a little wobble]
- [YOU SAY: answer "Tudo bem?" two ways — "Tudo bem!" / "Mais ou menos"]
- [YOU SAY: Portuguese *mais ou menos* = Spanish *más o menos*, same Latin *magis/minus*]



## Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does *mais ou menos* literally mean? (“More or less.”) What Latin words are *mais* and *menos* from, and their English cousins? (*magis* → major/ maximum; *minus* → minor/minus.) Which language’s shrug is its exact twin? (Spanish *más o menos*.) Next: put the whole exchange together.

## 2.7 Practice — Tudo bem?, start to finish

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] No new words. Assemble the chapter’s atoms into one casual exchange before adding the formal version.

### The exchange

— Olá! **Tudo bem?** — **Tudo bem, e você?** — **Mais ou menos.** — [after a small favour] Obrigado! — **De nada.**

The glue is **e você?**, “and you?”: **e** continues Latin *et*, while *você* grew from the respectful title *vossa mercê*.

### What you’ve built: What you are retrieving

- **de nada** — “of nothing,” you’re welcome;
- **tudo bem?** — the verb-free check-in;
- **como vai?** / **como está?** — “go” and “stand” alternatives;
- **mais ou menos** — “more or less,” so-so.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: the whole exchange, both voices]
- [YOU SAY: answer with “Tudo bem”]
- [YOU SAY: answer with “Mais ou menos”]

[REPEAT x2] “Tudo bem? — Tudo bem, e você?”

## Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Run the casual exchange without looking. Which phrase answers a small favour? (**De nada.**) Which answer means “so-so”? (**Mais ou menos.**) Which question is safest before choosing a register? (**Tudo bem?**) Next: rebuild the exchange with **o senhor** / **a senhora**.

## 2.8 Formal practice — Como está o senhor?

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] The casual exchange is secure. Now replace ordinary *você* with the respectful title **o senhor** or **a senhora**.

### The exchange

— Bom dia. **Como está o senhor?** — **Bem, obrigado. E o senhor?** — Tudo bem.

For a woman, use **a senhora**. The words continue Latin *senior*, “older,” the same root as English **senior** and Spanish *señor*.

The verb stays **está** because the title is grammatically third person: “How is the gentleman/lady?” That respectful grammar is already packed into the phrase; do not switch it to informal second-person *estás* here.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: to a man — “Como está o senhor?”]
- [YOU SAY: to a woman — “Como está a senhora?”]
- [YOU SAY: “Bem, obrigado. E o senhor?”]

[REPEAT x2] “Como está o senhor? — Bem, obrigado.”

## Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which titles mean a respectful “you”? (**O senhor** / **a senhora**.) Which verb form follows them? (**Está**, third person.)

Where does *senhor* come from? (Latin ***senior***, “older.”) You can now run the Chapter 2 exchange casually or formally.



## Chapter 3

# Introducing Yourself

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 3.1 eu — “I,” often dropped in Portuguese

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Before introducing yourself, meet **eu** — “I.” Famous English cousin, and the same habit as its Romance sisters: Portuguese usually **leaves it out**.

#### Sounds you’ll need

- **nasal-eu** — **eu** = *EH-oo*, a gliding vowel with a light nasal colour, one syllable.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**eu** = “I,” from Latin **ego** — the same *ego* English borrowed outright:

- **ego**, **egoist**, **egocentric** — all Latin “I.”
- Romance siblings, all from *ego*: Spanish **yo**, Italian **io**, French **je**.

#### Grammar Lens: the dropped subject (pro-drop)

The verb ending already names the speaker, so Portuguese usually **omits** the pronoun: *chamo-me* (“I call myself”) needs no *eu* — the *-o* of *chamo* is “I.” You add **eu** for **emphasis** or **contrast**:

*Eu* estou bem, e você? — “I’m fine, and you?”

Spanish (*yo*) and Italian (*io*) do the same. It's one of the first real habits of a Romance language: trust the verb ending, drop the pronoun.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "eu" — *EH-oo*]
- [YOU SAY: "eu" then English "ego, egoist" — the same Latin "I"]
- [YOU SAY: eu / yo / io / je — four children of *ego*]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What Latin word is *eu* from? (*Ego* — ego, egoist.) Why does Portuguese usually drop it? (The verb ending already says "I.") When do you keep it? (Emphasis / contrast.) Next: introduce yourself — **me chamo**.

## 3.2 me chamo — "I call myself"

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Like its Iberian and Italian sisters, Portuguese introduces you as what you **call yourself** — **me chamo** — from the very same Latin *clāmāre* that gave Spanish *me llamo* and Italian *mi chiamo*.

#### Sounds you'll need

- **ch-is-sh** — Portuguese **ch** = "sh": **chamo** = *SHAH-moo*. (A neat three-way split from one Latin *cl*:- Spanish *ll* = *y* (*llamo*), Italian *ch* = hard *k* (*chiamo*), Portuguese *ch* = *sh* (*chamo*).)
- **final-o-is-u** — final *-o* → *u*: *SHAH-moo*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**me chamo** = **me** ("myself") + **chamo** ("I call") → "**I call myself**." Brazilians often say **eu me chamo**; European Portuguese prefers **chamo-me** (same words, pronoun clipped to the back) — both fine. Then the name: *Me chamo Ana* — "I call myself Ana."

The verb **chamar-se** ("to call oneself") is from Latin **clāmāre**, "*to cry out, to call*" — shouting through English as **claim**, **exclaim**, **proclaim**, **clamor**. Three Romance naming verbs, one Latin call:

| language   | "I call myself"  | <i>cl-</i> became            |
|------------|------------------|------------------------------|
| Portuguese | <i>me chamo</i>  | <i>ch</i> (= <i>sh</i> )     |
| Spanish    | <i>me llamo</i>  | <i>ll</i> (= <i>y</i> )      |
| Italian    | <i>mi chiamo</i> | <i>ch</i> (= hard <i>k</i> ) |

**Another way to say it:** *o meu nome é ...* ("my name is ..."), where **nome** ← Latin **nōmen**, "name" — the root of English **noun**, **nominal**, **nomenclature**, **nominate**. Two routes to the same introduction: the *verb* (call myself) or the *noun* (my name is).

#### Grammar Lens: the reflexive

*chamo* alone = "I call [someone]"; **me chamo** = "I call **myself**" — reflexive. The pronoun shifts with the person: **me chamo** (I) → **se chama** (he/she/você). And *eu* is dropped — the *-o* ending already says "I."

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "me chamo" — *muh SHAH-moo*, *ch* = *sh*]
- [YOU SAY: "Me chamo ..." with your own name]
- [YOU SAY: *me chamo* / *me llamo* / *mi chiamo* — one *clāmāre*, three sounds]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does *me chamo* literally mean, and its Latin root? ("I call myself"; *clāmāre* — claim/clamor.) How is Portuguese *ch* pronounced, vs Italian *ch*? (Portuguese *sh*; Italian hard *k*.) What's the noun-route alternative? (*O meu nome é ...*, *nome* ← *nōmen*.) Next: ask it back — **Como se chama?**

### 3.3 Como se chama? — "what's your name?"

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Both pieces are yours: **como** ("how," from your *Tudo bem?* chapter) and **chamar-se** ("to call oneself"). Portuguese, like all its sisters, asks the name with "**how**": *how do you call yourself?*

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**Como se chama?** = "What's your name?" literally: "**How** do you call yourself?"

- **como** = "how" (← *quōmodo*).
- **se** = "yourself" (the reflexive; *me* → *se*).
- **chama** = "calls" (*você*/he-she form of *chamar-se*).

Portuguese register is friendly here — the everyday polite form uses **você**:

| form                                     | question                                   |
|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| polite / neutral ( <i>você</i> )         | <b>Como (você) se chama?</b>               |
| very formal                              | <b>Como se chama o senhor / a senhora?</b> |
| familiar ( <i>tu</i> , more in Portugal) | <b>Como te chamas?</b>                     |

The reply loops right back: *Me chamo Ana. E você?* And just like Spanish *¿cómo se llama?* and Italian *come ti chiami?*, the name is a matter of **how** you're called — never *what*.

#### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "Como se chama?" — *KOH-moo suh SHAH-mah*]
- [YOU SAY: the whole loop — "Como se chama? — Me chamo ... E você?"]
- [YOU SAY: *como se chama* / *cómo se llama* / *come ti chiami* — the same question, three sisters]



## Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does *Como se chama?* literally ask? ("How do you call yourself?") Which everyday pronoun does the polite form use? (*Você*.) What "how" word is it built on? (*Como* ← *quōmodo*.) Next: the warm reply — **prazer**.

### 3.4 **prazer** — "pleased to meet you," i.e. "a pleasure"

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Names traded, you close with **prazer** — "a pleasure." It's the twin of Italian *piacere*, and, like it, straight from Latin *please*.

## Sounds you'll need

- **pr-cluster** — **prazer** = *prah-ZEHR*: the *z* is a true *z*; stress the end. (The *pr-* shows a Portuguese sound-law: Latin *pl-* often became *pr-* — *placēre* → *prazer*, *plūs* → ...)

## The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**prazer** = "pleasure" (and, as a verb, "to please"), from Latin **placēre**, "to please." On meeting someone it's short for "[it's] a pleasure."

That *placēre* root is deep in English — **please**, **pleasure**, **pleasant**, **complacent**, **placid** — and it names this courtesy across the family:

- Italian **piacere** — its exact twin (same *placēre*).
- Spanish **mucho gusto** — "much pleasure," but from *gustus* ("taste"), a different root.
- French **enchanté** — a different picture again ("enchanted").

Portuguese took *placēre*'s *pl-* to *pr-* (a regular shift — compare *branco* "white" ← Germanic *blank*, *praia* "beach" ← *plagia*), so *piacere* and *prazer* look a little different but are the very same word.

**Grammar Lens: a one-word courtesy**

*Prazer* stands alone, with a nod or handshake. Fuller forms: **muito prazer** ("much pleasure"), or **prazer em conhecê-lo/-la** ("a pleasure to know you").

**Guided Practice**

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "prazer" — *prah-ZEHR*]
- [YOU SAY: "prazer" then English "please, pleasure, placid" — the *placēre* root]
- [YOU SAY: Portuguese *prazer* and Italian *piacere* — twins from *placēre*]

**Wrap-up recall**

[PAUSE 3s] What does *prazer* mean, and from what Latin verb? ("A pleasure," ← *placēre*.) Its Italian twin? (*Piacere*.) What sound-shift turned *pl-* into *pr-*? (The Portuguese *placēre* → *prazer* change.) Next: put the whole introduction together.

**3.5 Practice — introducing yourself in Portuguese**

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] No new words. *eu, me chamo, como se chama, prazer* assemble into a real first meeting. This slots between your greetings (Ch. 1–2) and farewells (Ch. 4), so Portuguese now runs a whole conversation.

**The exchange**

**Casual** (*você*):

— Olá! **Como você se chama?** — **Me chamo** Ana. E você?  
— João. **Prazer!** — Prazer!

**More formal** (o senhor / a senhora):

— Bom dia. **Como se chama a senhora?** — Chamo-me Ana Costa. E o senhor? — Costa. **Muito prazer.**

### What you've built this chapter

- **eu** — "I" (← *ego*), usually **dropped** — the verb ending carries it.
- **me chamo / chamo-me** — "I call myself" (*chamar-se* ← *clāmāre*; *ch* = *sh*; kin of *me llamo*, *mi chiamo*). Alt: *o meu nome é* (*nome* ← *nōmen*).
- **Como se chama?** — "how do you call yourself?" (polite *você*).
- **prazer** — "a pleasure" (← *placēre*; twin of Italian *piacere*).

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: the full casual meeting, both voices]
- [YOU SAY: the same formally — with *o senhor / a senhora*]
- [YOU SAY: chain it all — greet, name, ask, how-are-you, goodbye:  
"Olá! Me chamo ... Como se chama? ... Tudo bem? ... Até logo!"]

[REPEAT x2] Run a whole first meeting start to finish.

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Why does Portuguese usually drop *eu*? (The verb ending says who.) What does *me chamo* literally mean, and its root? ("I call myself"; *clāmāre*.) What does *prazer* mean, and its Italian twin? ("A pleasure"; *piacere*.) Portuguese now runs greet → introduce → how-are-you → goodbye, end to end — the fifth language to close the loop.



## Chapter 4

# Farewells

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 4.1 adeus — "goodbye," i.e. "to God"

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] You can greet, ask *tudo bem?*, and reply. Now close the conversation. The Portuguese goodbye is **adeus** — and it's a tiny prayer: **"to God."**

#### Sounds you'll need

- nasal-*eu* — **adeus**  $\approx$  *ah-DEH-oosh*: the *eu* is a gliding vowel; final *-s* is a soft *sh* in Portugal (*-s*  $\rightarrow$  *ss* in Brazil). Stress the *-deus*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**adeus** = **a** ("to") + **Deus** ("God"), from Latin **ad Deum**, "*to God*." It's the fossil of a blessing — "*[I commend you] to God*" — said at parting, exactly like the English **goodbye**, which is a worn-down "*God be with ye*."

This is one of the most beautiful family resemblances in the whole curriculum — five languages, one farewell prayer:

| language   | goodbye        | =                |
|------------|----------------|------------------|
| Portuguese | <i>adeus</i>   | a + Deus         |
| Spanish    | <i>adiós</i>   | a + Dios         |
| French     | <i>adieu</i>   | à + Dieu         |
| Italian    | <i>addio</i>   | a + Dio          |
| English    | <i>goodbye</i> | "God be with ye" |

The *Deus* here is the same one in English **deity**, **divine**, **adieu**, and Spanish *Dios*. When you say *adeus*, you're handing someone to God for safekeeping until next time.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "adeus" — *ah-DEH-oosh*]
- [YOU SAY: *adeus* / *adiós* / *adieu* / *addio* — one "to God" across four languages]
- [YOU SAY: even English "goodbye" = "God be with ye"]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does *adeus* literally mean, and from what? ("To God," ← *ad Deum*.) Name two sister-language goodbyes with the same "to God" origin. (*adiós*, *adieu*, *addio*.) What English goodbye hides "God be with ye"? (*Goodbye*.) Next: the softer "see you" goodbyes — starting with **até logo**.

## 4.2 até logo — "see you later," and a word straight from Arabic

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] The everyday Portuguese goodbye isn't *adeus* (that's a bit final) — it's **até logo**, "until soon." And its first word carries the same surprise Spanish's *hasta* does: it came from **Arabic**.

### Sounds you'll need

- **até** = *ah-TEH*, stress the end (the accent on *é*).
- **final-o-is-u** — **logo** = *LOH-goo*, final *-o* → *u*.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **até** = "until, up to." Like Spanish **hasta**, it comes from **Arabic** *ḥattā* (حتى), "until" — carried into Iberian speech across the **800 years of al-Andalus**. Both Iberian languages borrowed the *same* Arabic word for this everyday preposition. That's remarkable: languages freely borrow *nouns* (Portuguese has thousands from Arabic — *almofada*, *açúcar*, *azeite*), but a **function word** like "until" almost never crosses. *até* and *hasta* are twin survivors of that deep Arabic layer under Iberian Romance.
- **logo** = "soon, right away, then," from Latin **locō**, "*in [that] place*" → "on the spot" → "soon." (Spanish did the identical thing: **luego** ← *locō*, and *hasta luego* is the word-for-word twin of *até logo*.)

So **até logo** = "until soon" — the exact mirror of Spanish **hasta luego**, Arabic preposition and all.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "até logo" — *ah-TEH LOH-goo*]
- [YOU SAY: Portuguese *até* and Spanish *hasta* — both from Arabic *ḥattā*]
- [YOU SAY: *até logo* = *hasta luego*, twin for twin]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Where does *até* come from, and which Spanish word is its twin? (Arabic *ḥattā* — Spanish *hasta*.) Why is borrowing it surprising? (It's a *function word*; languages rarely borrow those.)

What does *logo* share with Spanish *luego*? (Both ← Latin *locō*, “in place” → “soon”.) Next: **até amanhã**.

### 4.3 até amanhã — “see you tomorrow”

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Same frame — *até* + a “when.” **Até amanhã** means “until tomorrow.” Its second word is the Portuguese cousin of a Spanish word you already know, wearing a heavy nasal ending.

#### Sounds you’ll need

- **nasal-anha** — **amanhã** = *ah-mah-NYÃ*: the **nh** is the *ny* of “canyon” (Portuguese spells the *ñ* sound as *nh*), and the final **-ã** is a strong **nasal a** — air through the nose, no hard consonant. Stress the end.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **até** = “until” (← Arabic *ḥattā*, from the last lesson).
- **amanhã** = “tomorrow,” from Latin **ad māneāna**, “to the morning [hour].”

That **māne** (“morning”) root is shared right across Romance — you’ve now met three of its children:

- Portuguese **amanhã** (“tomorrow”) ← *ad māneāna*.
- Spanish **mañana** — morning *and* tomorrow (the *ñ* spelled with the tilde).
- Italian **domani** (“tomorrow”) ← *dē māne*.

Same idea everywhere: tomorrow is “**the morning to come**.” Portuguese writes the *ny* sound as **nh** (*amanhã*), where Spanish uses **ñ** (*mañana*) — two spellings, one sound, both from that doubled-*n*.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]



- [YOU SAY: "até amanhã" — *ah-TEH ah-mah-NYÁ*, nasal ending]
- [YOU SAY: amanhã / mañana / domani — three children of *māne*, "morning"]
- [YOU SAY: Portuguese *nh* = Spanish *ñ* = the *ny* sound]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does *amanhã* come from, and literally mean? (*Ad māneāna* — "to the morning.") How does Portuguese spell the *ny* sound that Spanish writes as *ñ*? (As *nh*.) Next: "see you soon" — **até breve**.

## 4.4 até breve — "see you soon"

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] The last of the *até* goodbyes: **até breve**, "until soon" — literally "until [a] *short* [while]." *Breve* is a word English wears in several coats.

#### Sounds you'll need

- **até breve** = *ah-TEH BREH-vee*: open *e* in *breve*, final *-e* softens toward *ee*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **até** = "until" (← Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **breve** = "short, brief," from Latin **brevis**, "*short*."

You already own *brevis* in English, several times over:

- **brief** — short (a *brief* meeting; a legal *brief*).
- **brevity** — shortness ("brevity is the soul of wit").
- **abbreviate**, **abridge** — to make short.
- even the musical **breve** and the little **breve** mark <sup>˘</sup> over a short vowel.

So *até breve* is "until [a] **short** [**while**]" — see you before long. It's a touch warmer and less fixed than *até logo*; both mean "see you soon."

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "até breve" — *ah-TEH BREH-vee*]
- [YOU SAY: "breve" then English "brief, brevity, abbreviate" — one root]
- [YOU SAY: the three *até* goodbyes — até logo / até amanhã / até breve]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does *breve* mean, and its English cousins? ("Short" — brief, brevity, abbreviate.) So *até breve* literally says? ("Until a short while" → see you soon.) Next: put the Portuguese goodbyes together.

## 4.5 Practice — saying goodbye in Portuguese

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] No new words. You can now greet, ask *tudo bem?*, and **close** the conversation. Run the goodbyes until the right one is automatic.

### You'll want to know: The closings

**Final / formal** — the "to God" goodbye:

— Foi um prazer. **Adeus!**

**Everyday "see you"** — pick the *até* that fits:

— **Até logo!** (see you later / soon) — **Até amanhã!** (see you tomorrow) — **Até breve!** (see you soon)

**Casual chain** — greet and part:

— Olá! Tudo bem? ... **Até logo!** — **Até!** (Brazilians often clip it to just "*até!*")

### What you've built this chapter

- **adeus** — goodbye ("to God"; the *adiós* / *adieu* / *addio* family, and English *goodbye* = "God be with ye").
- **até logo** — see you later (*até* ← **Arabic** *ḥattā*, twin of Spanish *hasta*; *logo* ← *locō*, kin of *luego*). *Até logo* = *hasta luego*.
- **até amanhã** — see you tomorrow (*amanhã* ← *ad m̄aneāna*, kin of *mañana*; the *nh* = Spanish *ñ*).
- **até breve** — see you soon (*breve* ← *brevis*, "short" — brief/brevity).

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: greet, ask, and close — "Olá! Tudo bem? ... Até amanhã!"]
- [YOU SAY: choose the right goodbye — leaving for good / till tomorrow / soon]
- [YOU SAY: *até logo* and Spanish *hasta luego* — twins, Arabic *até/hasta* and all]

[REPEAT x2] Open and close a whole tiny exchange without stopping.

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which Portuguese goodbye means "to God"? (*Adeus*.) Which word inside the *até* goodbyes came from Arabic, and what's its Spanish twin? (*Até* ← *ḥattā* — Spanish *hasta*.) You can now run a Portuguese conversation start to finish — that's the fifth language to reach the full greet-to-goodbye arc.



## Chapter 5

# The First Verbs

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 5.1 **falar** — “to speak,” and the *f* that Spanish lost

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s]

Until now you’ve assembled fixed phrases. **Falar** (“to speak”) is your first real **verb** and the model for the large **-ar** family. Its first letter also hides a beautiful contrast with Spanish.

#### Sounds you’ll need

- **final-r** — **falar** = *fah-LAR*, tapped final *r*. The stem is *fal-*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**falar** comes from Latin **fabulārī**, “to chat, to tell tales” — from **fābula**, “a story” (→ English **fable**, **fabulous**, **confabulate**). The **same Latin verb as Spanish *hablar*** — but here’s the twist:

**Portuguese kept the Latin *f*-; Spanish turned *f*- into *h*-.** So the two “speak” verbs diverge at letter one, and the pattern runs through the whole vocabulary:

| Latin (f-)      | Portuguese (f-)        | Spanish (h-, silent) |
|-----------------|------------------------|----------------------|
| <i>fabulārī</i> | <b>falar</b>           | hablar               |
| <i>farīna</i>   | <b>farinha</b> (flour) | harina               |
| <i>filīus</i>   | <b>filho</b> (son)     | hijo                 |
| <i>facere</i>   | <b>fazer</b> (to do)   | hacer                |
| <i>ferrum</i>   | <b>ferro</b> (iron)    | hierro               |

So when a Spanish word starts with a silent *h*, its Portuguese twin usually still has the honest Latin *f* — *hijo/filho*, *hacer/fazer*. Portuguese is the more conservative sister here.

### Grammar Lens: the -ar present tense (pro-drop)

Drop **-ar** to get *fal-*, then add the endings:

| person         | ending     | <i>falar</i> →           |
|----------------|------------|--------------------------|
| (eu)           | <b>-o</b>  | <b>falo</b> (I speak)    |
| (tu)           | <b>-as</b> | <b>falas</b> (you speak) |
| (você/ele/ela) | <b>-a</b>  | <b>fala</b>              |
| (nós)          | -amos      | falamos                  |
| (vocês/eles)   | -am        | falam                    |

Like Spanish and Italian, **Portuguese drops the subject pronoun** — *falo* already says "I," so no *eu* needed. (Portuguese joins the *drop* camp: ES, PT, IT drop; FR, DE keep.)

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "falar" — *fah-LAR*]
- [YOU SAY: "falo, falas, fala" — no *eu* needed]
- [YOU SAY: *falar* ↔ *hablar*, *filho* ↔ *hijo* — Portuguese keeps the *f*, Spanish drops it to silent *h*]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What Latin verb is *falar* from, and which Spanish verb is its twin? (*fabulārī* — Spanish *hablar*.) What sound-law separates them? (Portuguese kept *f*-; Spanish shifted *f*- → *h*-: *filho/hijo*.) Does

Portuguese keep or drop the pronoun? (Drops it.) Next: **morar**, "to live."

## 5.2 **morar** — "to live," i.e. to *linger* somewhere

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] A second **-ar** verb — and a distinctive Portuguese choice. Where its sisters say "live" with *habitāre* ("keep having a place"), everyday Portuguese uses **morar** — from a verb that means to **linger**.

### Sounds you'll need

- **morar** = *moh-RAR*, tapped final *r*, clean vowels.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**morar** comes from Latin **morārī**, "*to delay, to linger, to tarry, to stay a while.*" To  *dwell* somewhere is, in Portuguese, to *linger* there — a softer, more temporary image than "keeping" a place. That *morārī* root survives in English in a couple of unexpected words:

- **moratorium** — an official *delay* (a pause on payments or actions).
- **demur** — to *linger / hesitate*, to raise an objection (*without demur*).

(Portuguese does also have *habitar* — the *habitāre* verb its sisters use — but it's formal; **morar** is what you actually say: *Onde você mora?*, "Where do you live?")

### Grammar Lens: same -ar template

| (eu) moro · (tu) moras · (você) mora | (-o / -as / -a) |  
| moramos · moram | |

**Moro em Lisboa.** — "I live in Lisbon."

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "morar" — *moh-RAR*]
- [YOU SAY: "moro, moras, mora"]
- [YOU SAY: "Onde você mora?" — "Where do you live?"; "morar"  
↔ *moratorium*]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What Latin verb is *morar* from, and what did it mean? (*morārī* — "to delay / linger.") English cousins? (*Moratorium*, *demur*.) Say "I live in Lisbon." (*Moro em Lisboa*.) Next: **trabalhar**, "to work."

### 5.3 trabalhar — "to work," and the torture returns

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] A third **-ar** verb — and Portuguese rejoins its Iberian sister on the darkest etymology in the curriculum. **trabalhar** ("to work"), like Spanish *trabajar*, began as a word for **torture**.

#### Sounds you'll need

- nasal-anha — the **-lh-** is a *ly* glide (as in Spanish *ll*):  
**trabalhar** = *tra-ba-LYAR*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**trabalhar** comes from Vulgar Latin **tripaliāre**, "to torture" — from **tripalium**, a Roman instrument of torture made of **three stakes** (*tri*—"three" + *pālus* "stake" → English *pale*, *impale*). *Torture* → *toil* → *work*, and English took the same road: **travail** (painful effort) → **travel** (a journey was an ordeal).

So Portuguese and Spanish are **twins** here — *trabalhar* and *trabajar*, both from *tripaliāre*. Only the middle consonant differs: Latin *-li-* became Portuguese **-lh-** (*trabalhar*) and Spanish **-j-** (*trabajar*). And this puts the "work" verbs of the five languages into two neat camps:

- **Torture** (*tripalium*): Portuguese *trabalhar*, Spanish *trabajar*, French *travailler*.



- **Labour** (*labor*): Italian *lavorare*.

Three languages remember work as *torture*; only Italy remembers it as *labour*.

#### Grammar Lens: same -ar template

| (eu) trabalho · (tu) trabalhas · (você) trabalha | (-o / -as / -a) |

**Trabalho no Porto.** — "I work in Porto."

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "trabalhar" — *tra-ba-LYAR*]
- [YOU SAY: "trabalho, trabalhas, trabalha"]
- [YOU SAY: trabalhar ↔ trabajar (twins) → travail → travel — torture to journey]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What did *trabalhar* originally mean, and from what device? ("To torture," ← *tripalium*, three stakes.) Its Spanish twin, and the one difference? (*trabajar*; Latin *-li-* → PT *-lh-* / ES *-j-*.) Which language uses "labour" instead? (Italian, *lavorare*.) Next: your first sentence — **Falo português**.

## 5.4 Falo português — your first real sentence

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] The payoff: you take a **verb** you conjugated and a **noun**, and build a sentence no one handed you — *Falo português*, "I speak Portuguese." (*Falo* covers both "I speak" and "I'm speaking.")

### You'll want to know: The new word: português

**português** = "Portuguese," from **Portus Cale** — a Roman-era port at the mouth of the **Douro** river (today's **Porto** / **Oporto**). *Portus* is Latin "port,

harbour” (→ English **port**, **portal**, **import**); **Cale** is older and debated — perhaps Celtic for “harbour/shelter,” or Latin *cālidus* “warm.” So *Portugal* began as a single **harbour town**, whose name spread to the whole country and its language. Say it *por-too-**GESH*** (final *-s* = *sh* in Portugal).

### You’ll want to know: The sentence, assembled

**Falo** (I speak, from *falar*) + **português** = **Falo português**.

A complete, grammatical Portuguese sentence. As before:

- **No *eu*.** The *-o* of *falo* says “I” — Portuguese drops the pronoun (like Spanish and Italian).
- **No article** on the language: *falo português*.

With this, **all five languages** you’ve been building now cross the same line — from reciting phrases to **making sentences**:

|            | <b>”I speak/learn [language]”</b> |
|------------|-----------------------------------|
| Spanish    | <b>Hablo</b> español              |
| Portuguese | <b>Falo</b> português             |
| Italian    | <b>Parlo</b> italiano             |
| French     | <b>Je parle</b> français          |
| German     | <b>Ich lerne</b> Deutsch          |

Swap the pieces: **Moro em Lisboa. · Trabalho no Porto. · Você fala português?**

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “Falo português” — *FAH-loo por-too-GESH*]
- [YOU SAY: drop the *eu* — Portuguese doesn’t need it]
- [YOU SAY: “português” ← *Portus Cale*, a single harbour town that named a nation]

## Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Where does *português* come from? (*Portus Cale*, a port at the Douro's mouth → Porto.) In *Falo português*, why no *eu* and no article? (The *-o* is "I"; languages take no article.) Which three of the five languages drop the pronoun? (Spanish, Portuguese, Italian.) Next: practice.

## 5.5 Practice — making sentences with -ar verbs

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] For the first time you're **building** Portuguese sentences from a pattern. Drill the three verbs until the endings are automatic — and remember, Portuguese drops the *eu*.

## Guided Practice: conjugate on command

[PAUSE 1s] Run each through *eu* / *tu* / *você* (pronoun dropped in speech):

- **falar:** falo · falas · fala
- **morar:** moro · moras · mora
- **trabalhar:** trabalho · trabalhas · trabalha

Same endings every time (**-o** / **-as** / **-a**), no pronoun needed.

## Guided Practice: say something real

— **Você fala** português? — **Falo** um pouco. E você? — Também. **Onde você mora?** — **Moro** em Lisboa, e **trabalho** no Porto. — Obrigado! — De nada.

## What you've built this chapter

- **the regular -ar present tense** — drop *-ar*, add *-o/-as/-a/-amos/-am*; pronoun **dropped** (like Spanish, Italian).
- **falar** (← *fabulārī* → fable; twin of Spanish *hablar* but with the *f* kept), **morar** (← *morārī* "to linger" → moratorium — a root no sibling uses), **trabalhar** (← *tripalium* "torture"; twin of *trabajar*).

- **Falo português** (← *Portus Cale*, a harbour town) — first self-assembled sentence, and the **fifth language** to cross from phrases into sentences.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: conjugate all three verbs, eu/tu/você — no pronoun spoken]
- [YOU SAY: answer about yourself — what you speak, where you live, where you work]
- [YOU SAY: chain it — "Olá! Falo português. Você fala português? ... Até logo!"]

[REPEAT x2] "Você fala português? — Falo um pouco."

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What are the three singular *-ar* endings? (*-o* / *-as* / *-a*.) Give the "I" forms of the three verbs. (*Falo, moro, trabalho.*) *falar* vs Spanish *hablar* — what's the sound-law difference? (Portuguese kept *f*-; Spanish shifted *f*→*h*.) All five of your languages now move in real sentences — the course has handed over rules, not phrases.

## Chapter 6

# Numbers One to Ten

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 6.1 um, dois, três, quatro, cinco — counting to five

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Portuguese counts almost like its sister Spanish — but with two signature Portuguese twists: heavy **nasal vowels**, and a number that still **changes for gender** where Spanish long stopped. Spanish twins are beside each.

#### Sounds you'll need

- **nasal-um** — **um** is nasal: *oong* said softly through the nose, no real *m*. (The *-m* is just the spelling for nasality, as in *sim*, *bom*.)
- **open-e** — **três** = *trehs* with an open *e* and the circumflex marking it.

## The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

| Portuguese        | ← Latin         | Spanish twin  | English cousins                                    |
|-------------------|-----------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>um</b> (1)     | <i>ūnus</i>     | <i>uno</i>    | <b>unit, union, unique</b> (and <i>a/an, one</i> ) |
| <b>dois</b> (2)   | <i>duo</i>      | <i>dos</i>    | <b>duo, dual, double</b>                           |
| <b>três</b> (3)   | <i>trēs</i>     | <i>tres</i>   | <b>trio, triple, triangle</b>                      |
| <b>quatro</b> (4) | <i>quattuor</i> | <i>cuatro</i> | <b>quart, quarter, quadrant</b>                    |
| <b>cinco</b> (5)  | <i>quīnque</i>  | <i>cinco</i>  | <b>quintet, quintessence</b>                       |

*Cinco* is spelled **identically** to Spanish — the two closest sisters. But watch *two*.

## Grammar Lens: um/uma and the gendered "two" (dois/duas)

**um** is also "a/an," gendered **um** (masc.) / **uma** (fem.): *um café, uma cerveja*. That much matches Spanish. The surprise is **two**: Portuguese still inflects it — **dois** (masc.) / **duas** (fem.) — a direct survival of Latin *duo* (masc.) / *duae* (fem.). So it's *dois cafés* but *duas cervejas*. Spanish levelled this to a single *dos* centuries ago; Portuguese kept the old split. The rest (*três, quatro, cinco*) don't change.

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "um, dois, três, quatro, cinco" — count up]
- [YOU SAY: the gendered two — "dois cafés" (masc.) / "duas cervejas" (fem.)]
- [YOU SAY: each with its English cousin — "dois/duo, três/trio, cinco/quintet"]

## Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Give 1–5 in Portuguese. (*Um, dois, três, quatro, cinco.*) Which number still changes for gender, and how? (*Two — dois / duas*, ← Latin *duo/duae*.) What does *um/uma* mean besides “one”? (“A/an.”) Next: **6–10**, where a Portuguese sound-shift is on full display.

## 6.2 seis, sete, oito, nove, dez — and the calendar’s secret

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] The rest of the way to ten. Like Spanish, Portuguese hides the calendar fact — **setembro–dezembro are Latin for 7, 8, 9, 10** — and one number, *oito*, puts a signature Portuguese sound-shift on full display.

## Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-oi — **oito** = *OY-too*, **dois** rhymes with it: the *oi* glide.
- **dez** = *dehs* (open *e*); the final *-z* is a soft “sh”/“s” in Portugal, “s” in Brazil.

## The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

| Portuguese      | ← Latin       | Spanish twin | English cousins                                                 |
|-----------------|---------------|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>seis</b> (6) | <i>sex</i>    | <i>seis</i>  | <b>sextet</b> ,<br><b>sextant</b>                               |
| <b>sete</b> (7) | <i>septem</i> | <i>siete</i> | <b>setembro</b> (the<br>7th month!),<br>septet                  |
| <b>oito</b> (8) | <i>octō</i>   | <i>ocho</i>  | <b>outubro</b> (8th),<br><b>octave</b> ,<br><b>octopus</b>      |
| <b>nove</b> (9) | <i>novem</i>  | <i>nueve</i> | <b>novembro</b><br>(9th), novena                                |
| <b>dez</b> (10) | <i>decem</i>  | <i>diez</i>  | <b>dezembro</b><br>(10th),<br><b>decimal</b> ,<br><b>dízimo</b> |

The star is **oito**. Latin *octō* had a *-ct-* cluster, and Portuguese turned every Latin *-ct-* into **-it-**: *octō* → *oito*, *noctem* → *noite* ("night"), *lactem* → *leite* ("milk"), *factum* → *feito* ("done"). So *oito*, *noite*, and *leite* all carry the same fingerprint — once you spot the *-it-*, you can often guess the Latin word had a *-ct-*. (Spanish took a different path: *octō* → *ocho*, with *-ct-* → *-ch-*. Same cluster, two sisters, two solutions — *oito* vs *ocho*.)

## Grammar Lens: why the months are "off by two"

*Setembro* means "7th," yet sits **9th**. The old **Roman year began in March**, so *September* really was the seventh; *julho* and *agosto* (July, August) were inserted later and shoved the counting months down. The Latin numbers stuck to the month names. Every *dezembro*, you're saying Roman **"ten"** — and *dez* also gave Portuguese *dízimo*, a "tithe" (a tenth), the twin of English *dime*.

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "seis, sete, oito, nove, dez" — finish the count]



- [YOU SAY: "sete/setembro, oito/outubro, nove/novembro, dez/dezembro"]
- [YOU SAY: the *-ct-* → *-it-* set — "oito, noite, leite" — then Spanish "ocho"]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Give 6–10 in Portuguese. (*Seis, sete, oito, nove, dez.*) What Latin cluster became *-it-* in *oito*, and one more example? (*-ct-*; *noite* ← *noctem* / *leite* ← *lactem*.) Why is *dezembro* Latin for "ten"? (The Roman year began in March.) Next chapter builds on this toward time and days.



## Chapter 7

# Days of the Week

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 7.1 segunda to sexta — the week that got numbered

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Here Portuguese does something **no other Romance language does**. French, Italian, and Spanish all name their weekdays for planet-gods (*lundi*, *lunedì*, *lunes* = the Moon). Portuguese threw the pagan gods out and **numbered** the days instead — and the numbers are the very ones you just learned.

#### Why it's said this way

In the 6th century, **Martinho de Braga**, a bishop in what is now northern Portugal, refused to let Christians name days after *Mars* and *Jupiter*. Borrowing the Church's word for the numbered holy days of Easter week, he called them **feiras** — and Portuguese alone kept the system for **every** week.

**feira** ← Latin **fēria**, "a feast-day / a day free of work." (The same *fēria* drifted, elsewhere, into "market/fair" — English **fair** is its cousin, because markets were held on feast-days.)

## Grammar Lens: The pattern: [ordinal] + feira

| Portuguese                     | means           | ← ordinal of                | (cardinal you learned) |
|--------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------|------------------------|
| <b>segunda</b> -feira<br>(Mon) | "2nd feast-day" | <i>secundus</i><br>"second" | <i>dois</i> (2)        |
| <b>terça</b> -feira<br>(Tue)   | "3rd"           | <i>tertius</i> "third"      | <i>três</i> (3)        |
| <b>quarta</b> -feira<br>(Wed)  | "4th"           | <i>quartus</i><br>"fourth"  | <i>quatro</i> (4)      |
| <b>quinta</b> -feira<br>(Thu)  | "5th"           | <i>quintus</i> "fifth"      | <i>cinco</i> (5)       |
| <b>sexta</b> -feira<br>(Fri)   | "6th"           | <i>sextus</i> "sixth"       | <i>seis</i> (6)        |

So *quarta-feira* is literally "**fourth** feast-day," and you can hear *quatro* (4) inside *quarta*. In everyday speech the "-feira" is often dropped: "*Até segunda!*" — "See you Monday!" (Why does Monday start at **two**, not one? Because Sunday is counted as the *first* day — the next lesson closes that loop.)

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "segunda, terça, quarta, quinta, sexta" — Monday through Friday]
- [YOU SAY: hear the number in each — "quarta ← quatro (4), quinta ← cinco (5), sexta ← seis (6)"]
- [YOU SAY: drop the tail — "Até sexta!" ("See you Friday!")]

## Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] How is Portuguese unique among Romance languages here? (It **numbers** its weekdays — *feiras* — instead of naming planet-gods.) What does *feira* mean, and its English cousin? ("Feast-day," ← *fēria*; English *fair*.) What number hides in *quinta-feira*? (Five — *quinta* ← *quintus*, cousin of *cinco*.) Next: the two days that **kept** their old names — *sábado* and *domingo*.

## 7.2 sábado and domingo — and why Monday is “the second”

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Five weekdays got numbered — but two kept their names. *Sábado* and *domingo* are the **religious anchors** of the Portuguese week, and *domingo* is the key that explains why the counting started where it did.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

| Portuguese     | ← Latin                                              | meaning                                | shared with                                                                |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>sábado</b>  | <i>Sabbatum</i> ←<br>Hebrew <i>shabbāt</i>           | the<br>” <b>Sabbath</b> ,”<br>rest-day | Spanish <i>sábado</i> ,<br>Italian <i>sabato</i> ,<br>French <i>samedi</i> |
| <b>domingo</b> | <i>(diēs)</i><br><i>Dominica</i> ←<br><i>Dominus</i> | ”the <b>Lord’s</b><br>day”             | Spanish<br><i>domingo</i> ,<br>Italian<br><i>domenica</i>                  |

- **sábado** is the **Sabbath**, from Hebrew *shabbāt* ”to rest” — the one weekend name every Romance language shares (even numbering-mad Portuguese kept it).
- **domingo** is ”the **Lord’s** day,” *diēs Dominica*, from *Dominus* ”lord, master” (→ English *dominion*, *dominate*, *dame*).

### Grammar Lens: domingo is ”day one” — so Monday is ”day two”

Now the loop closes. The Church counted **domingo (Sunday)** as the **first day** of the week — *prima feria*, the Lord’s day, the start. That’s why:

domingo = 1st → **segunda-feira** (Monday) = **2nd** → terça (3rd) → ... → sexta (Friday) = 6th → sábado (Saturday) = 7th.

Monday isn’t the first weekday in this system — it’s the day **after** the Lord’s day, the *second*. So *segunda-feira* (”second feast-day”) makes perfect sense once you know Sunday was counted first. The whole week is a countdown anchored on *domingo*.

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: the full week — "domingo, segunda, terça, quarta, quinta, sexta, sábado"]
- [YOU SAY: the anchors — "sábado = Sabbath, domingo = the Lord's day"]
- [YOU SAY: the logic — "domingo is 1st, so segunda (Monday) is 2nd"]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Give all seven Portuguese days. (*Domingo, segunda ... sábado.*) What does *domingo* mean, and why does that make Monday "*segunda*"? ("The **Lord's** day"; Sunday is counted **first**, so Monday is the **second**.) Which weekend name do all the Romance languages share? (*Sábado* — the Sabbath.) Next chapter builds on this toward telling the time.

## Chapter 8

# Telling Time

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 8.1 hora — the hour, said in full

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Portuguese "hour" is **hora**, from Latin **hōra** (← Greek *hōrā*) — the same word behind Spanish *hora*, French *heure*, and English *hour*. And unlike Italian, which hides the word, Portuguese keeps **horas** right out loud.

#### Sounds you'll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** of *hora* is silent (as everywhere in Portuguese): say *OH-ra*.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**hora** ← Latin **hōra** ← Greek **hōrā**, "a time of day." Portuguese kept the Latin spelling's silent *h*-, exactly as English *hour* does. Line the sisters up: *hora* / *hora* / *heure* / *Uhr* / *hour* — one Roman word (itself Greek-born) fanned across five languages.

#### Grammar Lens: "é uma hora" but "são duas horas"

Portuguese states the word **horas** in full, and the verb agrees with the number:

**É uma hora.** — "It is one o'clock." (singular: *é* "it is" +

*uma hora*) **São duas horas.** — "It is two o'clock." (plural: *são* "they are" + *duas horas*) **São dez horas.** — "It is ten o'clock."

Literally "**they are** two **hours**." Two things to notice, both from earlier chapters: the verb is **é** (one) vs **são** (two or more), like Italian *è/sono*; and **two** still shows gender — *duas horas* (feminine, agreeing with *horas*), the *dois/duas* split you met in the numbers.

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "hora" — *OH-ra*, silent h]
- [YOU SAY: "é uma hora ... são duas horas, são três horas"]
- [YOU SAY: "duas horas" — feminine *duas*, not *dois*]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What word is *hora* from, and its Spanish twin? (Latin *hōra* ← Greek *hōrā*; Spanish *hora*.) Why "*são duas horas*" but "*é uma hora*"? (Plural takes *são*; one o'clock is singular *é*.) Why *duas* and not *dois*? (*Horas* is feminine — the *dois/duas* gender split.) Next: **meio-dia** and **meia-noite** — noon and midnight.

## 8.2 meio-dia and meia-noite — noon and midnight

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Two named hours: **meio-dia** is noon; **meia-noite** is midnight. Each names the **middle** of the day or night, and *meia-noite* hides a sound-shift you already met in the numbers.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Both phrases begin with **meio/meia**, "half, middle." It comes from Latin **medius/media**, cousin of English *mid*, *medium* and Spanish *medio*:



| Portuguese        | =                          | ← Latin                         | literally                 |
|-------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>meio-dia</b>   | <i>meio</i> + <i>dia</i>   | <i>medius</i> + <i>diēs</i>     | "mid-day"<br>(noon)       |
| <b>meia-noite</b> | <i>meia</i> + <i>noite</i> | <i>media</i> +<br><i>noctem</i> | "mid-night"<br>(midnight) |

- **meio-dia** = "mid-day." *dia* ("day") ← *diēs*; *meio* is masculine (agreeing with the masculine *dia*).
- **meia-noite** = "mid-night." *meia* is **feminine** (for the feminine *noite*) — the *meio/meia* gender pair, like the *dois/duas* you know. And look at **noite**: it comes from Latin **noctem**, and the *-ct-* became *-it-* — *noctem* → *noite* — the **very same ct→it shift** that turned *octō* into *oito* ("8") in the numbers chapter. Spot *-it-* and you can often guess a Latin *-ct-* underneath.

To use them, they *are* the hour:

**É meio-dia.** — "It is noon." **É meia-noite.** — "It is midnight."

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "meio-dia" (noon), "meia-noite" (midnight)]
- [YOU SAY: break them — "meio (middle) + dia (day)", "meia + noite (night)"]
- [YOU SAY: the shift — "noite ← noctem, like oito ← octō"]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What do *meio-dia* and *meia-noite* literally mean? ("Mid-day" and "mid-night.") Why *meia-noite* but *meio-dia*? (*meia* feminine for *noite*, *meio* masculine for *dia*.) What earlier sound-shift is inside *noite*? (*ct→it*: *noctem* → *noite*, like *octō* → *oito*.) Next chapter builds on this toward months and family.



## Chapter 9

# Months and Seasons

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 9.1 os meses — the gods and numbers of the calendar

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] The Portuguese months are the Roman procession of gods and Caesars, worn down the Portuguese way. And two things you know pay off: *março* is the war-god, and *setembro-dezembro* are the Latin numbers 7–10.

## The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

| Portuguese       | ← Latin           | who / what                       | Spanish twin      |
|------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------|-------------------|
| <b>janeiro</b>   | <i>Januarius</i>  | <b>Janus</b> , god of beginnings | <i>enero</i>      |
| <b>fevereiro</b> | <i>Februarius</i> | the <i>Februa</i> purification   | <i>febrero</i>    |
| <b>março</b>     | <i>Martius</i>    | <b>Mars</b> , the war-god        | <i>marzo</i>      |
| <b>abril</b>     | <i>Aprilis</i>    | <i>aperire</i> "to open"         | <i>abril</i>      |
| <b>maio</b>      | <i>Maius</i>      | <b>Maia</b> , growth-goddess     | <i>mayo</i>       |
| <b>junho</b>     | <i>Junius</i>     | <b>Juno</b> , queen of gods      | <i>junio</i>      |
| <b>julho</b>     | <i>Julius</i>     | <b>Julius Caesar</b>             | <i>julio</i>      |
| <b>agosto</b>    | <i>Augustus</i>   | emperor <b>Augustus</b>          | <i>agosto</i>     |
| <b>setembro</b>  | <i>september</i>  | "7th" ( <i>septem</i> )          | <i>septiembre</i> |
| <b>outubro</b>   | <i>october</i>    | "8th" ( <i>octo</i> )            | <i>octubre</i>    |
| <b>novembro</b>  | <i>november</i>   | "9th" ( <i>novem</i> )           | <i>noviembre</i>  |
| <b>dezembro</b>  | <i>december</i>   | "10th" ( <i>decem</i> )          | <i>diciembre</i>  |

Portuguese tells: *janeiro/fevereiro* kept the *-eiro* ending (← *-arius*, the same suffix in *feira*), and *setembro/dezembro* echo the numbers *sete/dez* you learned. Two payoffs:

- **março = Mars.** The war-god's month, the same Mars behind English *March*.
- **setembro...dezembro = 7...10.** Still the Latin numbers, because the Roman year began in **March**; then *julho* (Julius) and *agosto* (Augustus) were inserted and pushed the count down two.

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: the twelve — "janeiro, fevereiro, março ... novembro, dezembro"]

- [YOU SAY: "março = Mars, the war-god"]
- [YOU SAY: "setembro = 7 (sete), dezembro = 10 (dez)"]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which god is *março* named for? (**Mars**, the war-god.) Why is *dezembro* Latin for "ten"? (The Roman year began in March.) Which two months honour real **people**? (*Julho* — Julius; *agosto* — Augustus.) Next: the **estações**, the seasons.

## 9.2 as estações — the seasons, and a shifting summer

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Four seasons — and a small mystery in one of them. Portuguese's word for **summer**, *verão*, didn't come from a "heat" word like French *été*. It grew out of the word for **spring**. Here's how.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

| Portuguese                     | ← Latin                 | literally                                                                          |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>a primavera</b><br>(spring) | <i>prīma vēra</i>       | " <b>first spring</b> / <b>first green</b> " ( <i>prīma</i> + <i>ver</i> "spring") |
| <b>o verão</b> (summer)        | <i>vēranum (tempus)</i> | "the <b>spring-like</b> / <b>warm</b> season" (← <i>vēr</i> "spring"!)             |
| <b>o outono</b> (autumn)       | <i>autumnus</i>         | "autumn" ( <i>ct/tumn</i> → <i>ut: autumnus</i> → <i>outono</i> )                  |
| <b>o inverno</b> (winter)      | <i>hibernum</i>         | "the wintry season" (cousin of <i>hibernate</i> )                                  |

The twist is in the first two, both born from Latin **vēr**, "spring":

- **primavera** = *prīma* + *ver*: "the **first** spring / first green" — the year's opening season (shared with Spanish and Italian).
- **verão** ← *vēranum*, which meant "**spring-like**, of the growing season." Warmth crept forward on the calendar, and the word

slid with it — so Portuguese’s “summer” literally *grew out of* “spring.” (Spanish did the same: *verano*.)

And **outono** ← *autumnus* shows a familiar Portuguese move: the *au...t* smoothed to **ou**, the same softening you saw in *oito* and *noite*.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “a primavera, o verão, o outono, o inverno”]
- [YOU SAY: the twist — “verão ← veranum ← ver (spring): summer from spring”]
- [YOU SAY: “inverno ~ hibernate”; “outono ← autumnus”]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Name the four Portuguese seasons. (*Primavera, verão, outono, inverno*.) What’s surprising about *verão*’s origin? (It comes from *vēr* “**spring**” — the summer-word grew out of the spring-word.) What does *primavera* literally mean? (“**First spring / first green**.”) Next chapter builds on this toward family and food.

## Chapter 10

# Family

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 10.1 o pai, a mãe — the family words worn to the bone

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Every Romance sister descends from *pater* and *māter*, but **Portuguese wore them down the furthest**. Italian kept *padre/madre*; French *père/mère*; Portuguese dissolved the middle consonant entirely, leaving the one-syllable **pai** and the nasal **mãe**.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **o pai** ("father") ← Latin **pater**. Portuguese dropped the intervocalic **-t-** completely: *pater* → *pae* → *pai*. The same disappearing--*t*- you saw in Ch.1's *noite* is here taken all the way to a bare diphthong.
- **a mãe** ("mother") ← Latin **māter**. Same loss of *-t-*, and the *a* soaked up a nasal from the lost *-n/-m-* environment → the tilde vowel **ã** (*mãe* = "mahng-ee," nasal).

Articles: *o* pai (masculine), *a* mãe (feminine).

**Grammar Lens: The plural trick — os pais**

Portuguese says **os pais** for “**the parents**” — but literally it is “**the fathers**.” Like Spanish *los padres*, the masculine plural **covers a mixed group**: one father + one mother = *os pais*. (And mind the spelling twin: **o país** — with an accent — means “**the country**”; *os pais* / *os países* are a classic pair to keep straight.)

The learned adjectives, borrowed back from Latin, still show the old root: **paternal**, **maternal** — so *pai* and *paternal* are the worn-down and the dressed-up versions of the same word.

**Guided Practice**

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “o pai, a mãe” — *mãe* fully nasal]
- [YOU SAY: the erosion — “*pater* → *pae* → **pai**; the *-t-* vanished”]
- [YOU SAY: “os pais = the parents (lit. ‘the fathers’); mind *o país* = country”]

**Wrap-up recall**

[PAUSE 3s] Give “father” and “mother” with articles. (**o pai, a mãe**.) What happened to the *-t-* of *pater/māter* in Portuguese? (It **vanished** — *pater* → *pae* → *pai*.) What does **os pais** mean literally and in use? (Literally “the fathers”; in use, “**the parents**.”) What word does *o país* (accented) mean? (The **country** — a spelling trap.) Next: **o irmão, a irmã** — and a surprise about where “brother” comes from.

**10.2 o irmão, a irmã — the brother who isn’t a “frater”**

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Every other track in this course builds “brother” from Latin *frāter* (French *frère*, Italian *fratello*). Portuguese — and Spanish with it — does something completely different, and it is one of the best etymologies in the whole language.



### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **o irmão** ("brother") and **a irmã** ("sister") come **not** from *frāter* but from Latin **germānus**, meaning "**genuine, of the same stock, born of the same parents.**"
- The Romans said **frāter germānus** — a "**full** brother," one sharing both parents, as opposed to a half-brother. Over time Iberian speakers **dropped the *frāter*** and kept the adjective: (*frāter*) *germānus* → *irmão*. So a Portuguese brother is literally a "**full-blood** one."

Articles: *o* irmão (masc.), *a* irmã (fem.); the masculine plural **os irmãos** covers a mixed set ("siblings"), exactly as *os pais* did for parents.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

That same *germānus* "of the same stock" fans out in English:

- **germane** — "relevant, closely related" (originally "having the same parents").
- **German** — the **people-name!** The Romans called the tribes across the Rhine *Germani*, plausibly "the genuine/kindred ones." So *irmão* ("brother") and *German* (the nation) spring from one Latin word for **kinship**.

Spanish made the **identical** swap — *hermano* / *hermana* — so Portuguese *irmão* and Spanish *hermano* are twins, both meaning "full-blood brother," both leaving *frāter* behind (kept only in bookish *fraternal* / *fraterno*).

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "o irmão, a irmã" — both nasal endings]
- [YOU SAY: the origin — "*frāter germānus* → drop *frāter* → **irmão**, 'full brother'"]
- [YOU SAY: the cousins — "*germano* → *germane*, and *German* the people"]

- [YOU SAY: the twin — "Portuguese *irmão* = Spanish *hermano*"]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Give "brother" and "sister" with articles. (**o irmão, a irmã.**) What Latin word are they from — and what did it mean? (**germānus** — "genuine, of the same parents"; from *frāter germānus*, "full brother.") Name two English cousins of *germānus*. (**germane; German**, the people-name.) What is the Spanish twin of *irmão*? (*hermano*.) Next chapter: sentences about the whole family.

## Chapter 11

# Bread, Water, and Wine

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 11.1 o pão — bread, worn down to a hum

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] **o pão** ("bread") — and Portuguese does to it exactly what it did to "father." Just as *pater* eroded to the one-syllable **pai**, Latin *pānis* wore down to the single **nasal** syllable **pão** ("powng"). Same word as French *pain* and Italian *pane*, taken furthest.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **o pão** ("bread") ← Latin **pānis**. The intervocalic *-n-* dissolved and left its **nasality** behind on the vowel: *pānis* → *pāe* → *pão*, the tilde marking the hum — the identical process behind **pai** (← *pater*) and **mãe** (← *māter*) from the family chapter. Masculine: *o* pão; the plural is the tricky **pães**.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Even worn to a hum, the root keeps its English relatives: **companion** / **company** (*com-* + *pānis*, "one you **share bread with**"), **pantry**, **pannier**. So *pão* and *companion* are the near-vanished and the well-preserved ends of one Latin word.

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "o pão" — fully nasal, "powng"; plural "pães"]
- [YOU SAY: the parallel — "*pater* → **pai**, *pānis* → **pão** — same nasal erosion"]
- [YOU SAY: "pão → companion, pantry"]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Give "bread" with its article. (**o pão**.) What Latin word is it from, and what happened to it? (*pānis* — worn to a single **nasal** syllable, *pānis* → *pão*.) Which family word followed the *same* erosion? (**pai**, ← *pater* — and *mãe* ← *māter*.) Next: **a água** and **o vinho** — water and wine.

## 11.2 a água, o vinho — water and wine

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Two drinks, two more sound-stories. Portuguese kept **água** close to Latin *aqua* (unlike French, which dissolved it to *eau*), and it stamps **vinho** with its signature spelling — the **-nh-**.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **a água** ("water") ← Latin **aqua**. Portuguese held its body — *aqua* → *água* — where French wore it down to a single vowel (*eau*). The accent on **á** marks the stress. It's **feminine**: *a água*. English kept the loud original in **aquatic**, **aquarium**, **aqueduct**.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **o vinho** ("wine") ← Latin **vīnum**. The **-nh-** is Portuguese's palatal *ny* sound — the **same sound** as Spanish **ñ** (*viño* → *vinho*), French/Italian **gn**, and the *nh* you already met in *amanhã* ("tomorrow"). One sound, four spellings across the sisters. The word still gives English **wine**, **vine**, **vinegar**, **vintage**. Masculine: *o vinho*.

**Guided Practice**

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "a água, o vinho" — stress the *á*; *-nh-* = palatal *ny*]
- [YOU SAY: the contrast — "*aqua* → **água** (kept), French **eau** (worn away)"]
- [YOU SAY: "the *nh* of *vinho* = Spanish *ñ*, met before in *amanhã*"]

**Wrap-up recall**

[PAUSE 3s] Give "water" and "wine" with articles. (**a água, o vinho.**) How does *água* compare with French *eau*, from the same *aqua*? (Portuguese **kept** the body; French wore it to a vowel.) What sound is the **-nh-** in *vinho*, and its Spanish twin? (A palatal *ny* — Spanish **ñ**.) Next chapter: asking for these at a table.



## Chapter 12

# Numbers Eleven to Twenty

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 12.1 onze → quinze — the short list

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Portuguese inherited the same welded Latin teens as its sisters — but it kept **fewer of them than anyone**. Just **five**. After *quinze* (15), it starts over with a completely different, much plainer method.

#### Grammar Lens: The five fusions

|    | Portuguese     | ← Latin              | build       |
|----|----------------|----------------------|-------------|
| 11 | <b>onze</b>    | <i>ūndecim</i>       | "one-ten"   |
| 12 | <b>doze</b>    | <i>duodecim</i>      | "two-ten"   |
| 13 | <b>treze</b>   | <i>trēdecim</i>      | "three-ten" |
| 14 | <b>catorze</b> | <i>quattuordecim</i> | "four-ten"  |
| 15 | <b>quinze</b>  | <i>quīndecim</i>     | "five-ten"  |

The shared **-ze** is Latin **decem** ("ten") worn thin — the same ten inside **dez** (10) and **dezembro** (the old 10th month, from Chapter 9). The digit sits at the front: *dois*→*do*-, *três*→*tre*-, *quatro*→*cator*-, *cinco*→*quin*-.

Note **catorze** — Portuguese kept the *c*- where Spanish says *catorce* and French *quatorze*; three worn-down versions of one Latin *quattuordecim*.

**What you've built: And that's where it stops**

*Quinze* is the **last** fused number. From **16** Portuguese does something none of its sisters do so early — the next lesson.

**Guided Practice**

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "onze, doze, treze, catorze, quinze"]
- [YOU SAY: the ten inside — "-ze = *decem* = **dez**"]
- [YOU SAY: the digit inside — "**três** → **treze**, **cinco** → **quinze**"]

**Wrap-up recall**

[PAUSE 3s] Count 11 to 15. (*Onze, doze, treze, catorze, quinze.*) What is the **-ze**? (Latin **decem**, "ten" — as in *dez, dezembro.*) How many fused teens does Portuguese keep, and is that more or fewer than its sisters? (**Five** — **fewer**; French and Italian keep six.) Next: **16**, where Portuguese starts building numbers a brand-new way.

## 12.2 dezesseis → vinte — built from scratch, with the "and" still showing

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] At **16**, Portuguese stops inheriting and starts **building**. And it does it more openly than any sister: it glues together the living words for "ten," "and," and the digit — and leaves the **and** right there in the middle where you can hear it.



**Grammar Lens: Ten AND six**

|           | Portuguese       | build                     | literally            |
|-----------|------------------|---------------------------|----------------------|
| 15        | <b>quinze</b>    | (fused,<br>inherited)     | "five-ten"           |
| <b>16</b> | <b>dezesseis</b> | <b>dez + e +<br/>seis</b> | <b>"ten and six"</b> |
| 17        | <b>dezessete</b> | dez + e + sete            | "ten and seven"      |
| 18        | <b>dezoito</b>   | dez + oito                | "ten eight"          |
| 19        | <b>dezenove</b>  | dez + e + nove            | "ten and nine"       |
| 20        | <b>vinte</b>     | ← <i>vīgintī</i>          | —                    |

Every one begins with **dez** ("ten," Chapter 6) and most keep **e** ("and") — so *dezesseis* is transparently a little sentence: *ten-and-six*. (*Dezoito* swallows the *e* before the vowel of *oito*.) You already know every ingredient; nothing here needs memorising, only assembling.

**What you've built: Portuguese breaks earliest**

All three Romance sisters give up fusing partway through the teens — but Portuguese gives up **first**:

| language          | last fused         | goes transparent<br>at         |
|-------------------|--------------------|--------------------------------|
| <b>Portuguese</b> | <i>quinze</i> (15) | <b>16</b> — <i>dezesseis</i>   |
| French            | <i>seize</i> (16)  | <b>17</b> — <i>dix-sept</i>    |
| Italian           | <i>sedici</i> (16) | <b>17</b> — <i>diciassette</i> |

One inherited Latin system, three different breaking points — and Portuguese is the boldest rebuilders. (German, by contrast, never breaks at all.)

**vinte** (20) ← *vīgintī*, the same root as French *vingt*, Italian *venti*, and English **vigesimal**.

**Guided Practice**

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: 15→20 — "quinze, dezesseis, dezessete, dezoito, dezenove, vinte"]
- [YOU SAY: hear the sentence — "*dez e seis* — ten AND six"]

- [YOU SAY: the whole run, onze to vinte]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does **dezesseis** literally spell out? (“**Ten and six**” — *dez + e + seis*.) At which number does Portuguese break, and how does that compare with French and Italian? (At **16** — **earlier**; they break at 17.) Why does *dezoito* have no *e*? (It’s **swallowed** before the vowel of *oito*.) Next chapter: numbers in use.

## Chapter 13

# Colours

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 13.1 preto, branco — two blacks and a borrowed white

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Portuguese does something the other Romance languages don't: it keeps **two words for black**, and the everyday one isn't the Latin one at all.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

| word         | source                                   | use                             |
|--------------|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| <b>negro</b> | Latin <i>niger</i>                       | literary, formal, fixed phrases |
| <b>preto</b> | Latin <i>pressus</i><br>"pressed, dense" | the <b>everyday</b> colour word |

*Negro* is the expected inheritance — the same *niger* that gave French *noir* and Italian *nero*. But day to day, Portuguese reaches for **preto**, from *pressus* ("pressed together, compact"). Dense → thick → **dark**: a colour named for how **packed** it is, not for its shade.

You already know *pressus*'s English children: *press*, *pressure*, *compress*.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's white, *albus*, lost here too. Portuguese says **branco**, from Germanic *blank* ("shining") — the same loan that gave French *blanc* and Italian *bianco*, arriving with the Suevi and Visigoths who settled Iberia. Notice what Portuguese did to the shape: *blanc-* → **branc-**. The **l** → **r** swap is a Portuguese signature (compare *plaza* → **praça**, *blando* → *brando*).

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

| word                   | meaning                    |
|------------------------|----------------------------|
| <b>alvorada</b>        | dawn (the sky going white) |
| <b>alva</b>            | white, dawn (poetic)       |
| <i>albumina, álbum</i> | (technical borrowings)     |

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "preto, branco"]
- [YOU SAY: "o vinho branco" — Chapter 11's wine]
- [YOU SAY: "o pão é branco" — Chapter 11's bread]
- [YOU SAY: the l→r swap — "blanc → **branco**"]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What are Portuguese's two blacks? (**Negro** ← *niger*, literary; and **preto** ← *pressus* "pressed/dense," the everyday one.) Why would "pressed" mean black? (**Dense** → **thick** → **dark**.) Where does **branco** come from? (**Germanic blank**, "shining" — borrowed **into** Romance.) What sound change shows in *branco*? (**l** → **r**, as in *praça*.) Next: **vermelho**, the strangest colour word in the language.

## 13.2 vermelho, azul — a worm and a stone

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] These two are the best etymologies in the whole chapter. Portuguese named its red after an **insect**

and its blue after a **rock**.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Every other Romance language builds "red" on the ancient root *h<sub>1</sub>rewd<sup>h</sup>* (*rouge*, *rosso*, Spanish *rojo*, and English *red*, German *rot*). Portuguese went its own way.

**vermelho** ← Latin *vermiculus*, "little worm" — the diminutive of *vermis*, "worm."

Why? Because the finest red dye in the ancient Mediterranean came from **kermes**, a scale insect harvested off oak trees and crushed for its pigment. Dyers called the creature a "little worm," and eventually the **dye's name became the colour's name**.

The same word gave English **vermilion**. And *vermis* gave English **vermin**.

Portuguese does still keep the old root — in **rubro** (literary "red") and **ruivo** ("red-haired") — but the everyday word for red is a bug.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**azul** ← Arabic *lāzaward* ← Persian *lāžward*: **lapis lazuli**, the deep-blue stone mined for millennia in Afghanistan and ground into the most expensive pigment in the medieval world.

The initial *l-* was lost — Spanish and Portuguese ears took it for the article *l'* and dropped it — leaving *azul*. The same journey produced French **azur**, Italian **azzurro**, and English **azure**.

This is the **al-Andalus** thread again: eight centuries of Arabic in Iberia left Portuguese and Spanish thousands of words, and one of them is a basic colour.

#### What you've built: The chapter in one table

| Portuguese | source                                       |
|------------|----------------------------------------------|
| preto      | Latin <i>pressus</i> "pressed"               |
| branco     | <b>Germanic</b> <i>blank</i> "shining"       |
| vermelho   | Latin <i>vermiculus</i> "little worm"        |
| azul       | <b>Arabic</b> <i>lāzaward</i> "lapis lazuli" |

Not one of Portuguese's four basic colours is a plain inherited Latin colour word.

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "vermelho, azul"]
- [YOU SAY: "o vinho é vermelho... o vinho tinto" — note: **wine** is *tinto*, "dyed"]
- [YOU SAY: "vermelho — vermilion — vermin"]
- [YOU SAY: all four — "preto, branco, vermelho, azul"]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does **vermelho** literally come from? (*Vermiculus*, "little worm" — the **kermes** insect crushed for dye.) Which English word is its sibling? (**Vermilion**.) Where does **azul** come from? (**Arabic** *lāzaward*, "lapis lazuli," via Persian — the *l-* lost as if an article.) What's odd about all four Portuguese colours? (**None** is a plain inherited Latin colour word.) Next chapter: describing what you see.

## Chapter 14

# Having and Telling Your Age

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 14.1 ter — "to have"

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Every Romance language needs a word for "have." French and Italian took one from Latin; **Portuguese and Spanish took a different one entirely** — and it didn't originally mean "have" at all.

#### You'll want to know: The forms

---

---

|                |              |
|----------------|--------------|
| (eu)           | <b>tenho</b> |
| (tu)           | <b>tens</b>  |
| (ele/ela/você) | <b>tem</b>   |
| (nós)          | <b>temos</b> |
| (vocês/eles)   | <b>têm</b>   |

---

Two things to watch:

- **tenho** — the **-nh-** (Portuguese's palatal *ny*, = Spanish **ñ**), already met in *vinho* (Ch. 11) and *amanhã*.
- **tem** vs **têm** — "he has" vs "**they** have". They sound nearly alike; the **circumflex** marks the plural. An accent doing grammar, not sound.

## The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**ter** ← Latin *tenēre*, "to hold" — not "to have."

| language   | "to have"    | ← Latin                 |
|------------|--------------|-------------------------|
| French     | <i>avoir</i> | <i>habēre</i>           |
| Italian    | <i>avere</i> | <i>habēre</i>           |
| Portuguese | <b>ter</b>   | <i>tenēre</i> "to hold" |
| Spanish    | <b>tener</b> | <i>tenēre</i> "to hold" |

Portuguese *does* still have **haver** (← *habēre*) — but it got demoted to an auxiliary and to *há* ("there is"). So on the Iberian peninsula the two verbs **swapped jobs**: "hold" moved up to mean *have*, and "have" moved down to a grammar word.

English kept the *tenēre* family as borrowings: **tenant** (one who *holds* land), **retain**, **maintain**, **tenacious**, **tenure**, **contain**.

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "tenho, tens, tem, temos, têm"]
- [YOU SAY: the **-nh-** — "tenho", like *vinho*]
- [YOU SAY: "Tenho um irmão" ("I have a brother") — Ch. 10's family]
- [YOU SAY: the hold-family — "ter · tenant · retain · tenacious"]

## Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What did *ter*'s Latin source mean? (***Tenēre*** — "to hold".) Which other language made the same swap? (**Spanish**, *tener*.) What happened to Portuguese's *habēre* verb? (It became **haver** — an auxiliary, and *há* "there is".) What separates *tem* from *têm*? (The **circumflex** — singular vs plural.) Next: the question *ter* is used for that English would never use "have" for.

14.2 *tenho vinte anos* — holding your years

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Portuguese states age with **ter**. And since *ter* came from "to hold," the sentence is, at the root, "I



**hold twenty years**” — the most physical version of this idea in any of the five languages.

### You’ll want to know: The phrase

**Quantos anos tens?** — “How many years do you **have**?”  
**Tenho vinte anos.** — “I **have** twenty years.”

*Ser* is wrong here. And **anos** can’t be dropped, unlike English “I’m twenty.”

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**ano** (“year”) ← Latin *annus* → English **annual**, **anniversary**, **annals**.  
 Now compare the two Iberian sisters:

| Latin        | Portuguese | Spanish    |
|--------------|------------|------------|
| <i>annus</i> | <b>ano</b> | <b>año</b> |

The Latin **-nn-** went two ways: Portuguese **simplified** it to a plain *n*, Spanish **palatalized** it into **ñ**. Same word, same peninsula, two outcomes — and this is exactly where Spanish’s *ñ* came from in the first place: doubled Latin *n*.

Careful: keep *ano* distinct from *ânus*. The stress and the circumflex do the work.

#### Grammar Lens: Who has, who is

| language   |                                  | literally         |
|------------|----------------------------------|-------------------|
| Portuguese | <i>tenho vinte anos</i>          | I <b>hold</b> ... |
| Spanish    | <i>tengo veinte años</i>         | I <b>hold</b> ... |
| French     | <i>j’ai vingt ans</i>            | I <b>have</b> ... |
| Italian    | <i>ho venti anni</i>             | I <b>have</b> ... |
| German     | <i>ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt</i> | I <b>am</b> ...   |
| English    | <i>I am twenty</i>               | I <b>am</b> ...   |

Three layers: Germanic **is** its years, French and Italian **have** them, and Iberian Romance **holds** them.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "Quantos anos tens?"]
- [YOU SAY: "Tenho vinte anos"]
- [YOU SAY: your own age, using Ch. 12's numbers]
- [YOU SAY: the sister pair — "**ano** ... **año**" — one Latin *annus*]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which verb does Portuguese use for age? (***Ter***, never *ser*.) Given *ter*'s root, what does the sentence literally say? ("I **hold** twenty years.") Where does *ano* come from? (Latin ***annus***.) What did Portuguese and Spanish each do with the **-nn-**? (PT **simplified** it to *n*; ES **palatalized** it to **ñ**.) Which two languages say "I **am**" instead? (**German and English**.)

## Chapter 15

# The Past Portuguese Kept

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 15.1 falei — the past Portuguese kept

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Portuguese’s everyday past tense. Its interest isn’t its endings — it’s that Portuguese still **has** it in daily speech, when several sisters do not.

#### You’ll want to know: The forms

---

|                |                                                        |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| (eu)           | <b>falei</b>                                           |
| (tu)           | <b>falaste</b>                                         |
| (ele/ela/você) | <b>falou</b>                                           |
| (nós)          | <b>falámos</b> (Portugal) / <b>falamos</b><br>(Brazil) |
| (vocês/eles)   | <b>falaram</b>                                         |

---

One word. No auxiliary, no participle — the verb carries the past by itself.

The *nós* form is worth a note: Portugal writes **falámos** with an accent to separate it from the present *falamos*, while Brazil writes both **falamos** and lets context decide. Same word, one accent, two spelling conventions.

**falei** ← Vulgar Latin perfect **\*fabulāvī**, the same source as Spanish *hablé*. The Latin *-āv-* dissolved and left a **stressed final vowel** behind, which is why *falei* and *falou* end where they do.

**Why it's said this way**

Now the point of the chapter:

| language   | this tense      | where it lives now                        |
|------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Portuguese | <i>falou</i>    | everyday speech                           |
| Spanish    | <i>habló</i>    | everyday speech                           |
| Italian    | <i>parlò</i>    | south yes, north<br>literary              |
| German     | <i>sagte</i>    | retreating, standard<br>in <b>writing</b> |
| French     | <i>il parla</i> | <b>literature only</b>                    |

All five inherited the same thing. French, German and northern Italy each built a compound past out of "have" and let it push the old simple past out of conversation. **Portuguese and Spanish, at the western edge of the map, didn't.**

Portuguese has all the parts to build a compound — *ter* from Chapter 14, and a participle (*falado*). It simply doesn't use them for this job. The next lesson shows what it uses them for instead.

**Guided Practice**

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "falei, falaste, falou, falámos, falaram"]
- [YOU SAY: "Ontem falei com a minha mãe" ("Yesterday I spoke with my mother")]
- [YOU SAY: "Trabalhei" — Ch. 5's verb in the past]
- [YOU SAY: the five fates — "falou · habló · parlò · sagte · il parla"]

**Wrap-up recall**

[PAUSE 3s] How many words does the Portuguese past need? (**One** — no auxiliary.) Where does *falei* come from? (Vulgar Latin perfect **\*fabulāvī**, like Spanish *hablé*.) Which two languages kept this tense in everyday speech? (**Portuguese and Spanish.**) Which one exiled it to literature? (**French.**) Next: what Portuguese does with *ter* +

participle, since it isn't this.

## 15.2 tenho falado — the compound that means something else

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Portuguese **does** have *ter* + participle. It looks exactly like the French and Italian compound past, and it means **something different**. This is one of the most common mistakes English speakers make in Portuguese.

You'll want to know: The form

**ter** (conjugated) + **past participle**

| infinitive | participle |
|------------|------------|
| falar      | falado     |
| comer      | comido     |
| partir     | partido    |

→ **tenho falado, tens falado, tem falado...**

### Grammar Lens: What it actually means

| Portuguese   | English                                                      |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| falei        | "I spoke" — one finished event                               |
| tenho falado | "I <b>have been</b> speaking" —<br><b>repeatedly, lately</b> |

*Tenho falado com ele* does **not** mean "I have spoken to him [once]." It means "I **have been** speaking to him" — **more than once, over a recent stretch of time, and it may still be going on.**

For a single completed act, Portuguese uses the simple past from the last lesson:

**Falei com ele ontem.** — "I spoke with him yesterday."

### Why it's said this way

French and Italian let their compound take over the plain past, so *j'ai parlé* and *ho parlato* now just mean "I spoke."

Portuguese never did — **falei** was already occupying that slot and never left. So when Portuguese assembled the same *have* + participle machinery, there was **no vacancy**, and the construction drifted into a different job: **repeated or continuing** action.

Same parts, same era, same family. Different outcome, because of what was already in the way.

| language   | have + participle means                                 |
|------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| French     | <i>j'ai parlé</i> — I spoke                             |
| Italian    | <i>ho parlato</i> — I spoke                             |
| German     | <i>ich habe gesagt</i> — I said                         |
| Portuguese | <i>tenho falado</i> — I have been speaking (repeatedly) |

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: the contrast — "**falei** I spoke · **tenho falado** I've been speaking"]
- [YOU SAY: "Falei com ele ontem" — one event]
- [YOU SAY: "Tenho falado com ele" — repeatedly, lately]
- [YOU SAY: the warning — "*tenho falado* is **not** 'I have spoken'"]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does *tenho falado* mean? ("I **have been** speaking" — **repeatedly**, over a recent stretch.) What do you use for one finished act? (The simple past — **falei**.) Why doesn't Portuguese's compound mean "I spoke"? (Because **falei never vacated** that slot, so the new construction took a different job.) Which languages let their compound take over the plain past? (**French, Italian, German.**)

## Chapter 16

# Ser and Estar

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 16.1 ser — “to be”

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Portuguese has two verbs for “to be.” Begin with **ser**, used for identity and what something is; the choice against *estar* comes later.

#### You’ll want to know: Present

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|                       |                            |
|-----------------------|----------------------------|
| eu <b>sou</b>         | nós <b>somos</b>           |
| tu <b>és</b>          | ~~vós <b>sois</b> ~~       |
| ele/ela/você <b>é</b> | eles/elas/vocês <b>são</b> |

---

*Tu és* is live in European Portuguese. **Vós** survives mainly in northern dialect and church language; everyday “you all” is **vocês**, with **são**.

#### You’ll want to know: Two past rows

Preterite, the completed past from Chapter 15:

**fui, foste, foi, fomos, foram**

Imperfect, for background or ongoing past:

**era, eras, era, éramos, eram**

The three anchors **sou** — **fui** — **era** look unrelated. That is a clue that several historical pieces have been welded together, which the next lesson will unpack. For now, retrieve each row as a usable pattern.

## Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “sou, és, é, somos, são”]
- [YOU SAY: “Eu sou português. Ela é médica.”]
- [YOU SAY: “fui, foste, foi, fomos, foram”]
- [YOU SAY: “era, éramos, eram”]

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Give the present of *ser*. (**Sou, és, é, somos, são.**) Which form goes with *vocês*? (**São.**) Give the preterite row. (**Fui, foste, foi, fomos, foram.**) Which imperfect form means “I was”? (**Era.**) Next: why those rows look so different.

## 16.2 ser — two verbs, three stems

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] **Sou, era, fui, ser** do not resemble one another because the modern verb preserves several older roots.

| Portuguese                    | source                                    |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| <b>sou, és, é, somos, são</b> | Latin <i>esse</i> , “to be”               |
| <b>era, éramos, eram</b>      | <i>esse</i> ’s imperfect                  |
| <b>fui, foi, foram</b>        | <i>esse</i> ’s ancient perfect <i>fuī</i> |
| infinitive <b>ser</b>         | Latin <i>sedēre</i> , “to sit”            |

That is **two Latin verbs** but **three stems**: *esse* was already suppletive, using both its ordinary root and the older *fuī* perfect. *Sedēre* also gave English **sedentary** and **session**.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The entire preterite is shared with **ir**, “to go”:



| person | ser          | ir           |
|--------|--------------|--------------|
| eu     | <b>fui</b>   | <b>fui</b>   |
| tu     | <b>foste</b> | <b>foste</b> |
| ele    | <b>foi</b>   | <b>foi</b>   |
| nós    | <b>fomos</b> | <b>fomos</b> |
| eles   | <b>foram</b> | <b>foram</b> |

**Fui professor** means “I was a teacher”; **fui ao Brasil** means “I went to Brazil.” What follows disambiguates them. *Fui* already belonged to *ser*’s ancestor; *ir* borrowed the row after Latin *īre*’s own perfect wore away. Spanish made the same Iberian choice.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “ser ← sedēre, to sit”]
- [YOU SAY: “sou / era ← esse”]
- [YOU SAY: “fui professor; fui ao Brasil”]

[REPEAT x2] “Two verbs, three stems; *fui* has two meanings.”

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which Latin verb gives the infinitive? (***Sedēre***, “*sit*.”) Which gives *sou* and *era*? (***Esse***.) What two verbs share *fui*? (***Ser*** and ***ir***.) Which borrowed it? (***Ir***.) Next: put *ser* beside *estar*.

## 16.3 ser vs. estar — the core choice

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Chapter 2 used **Como está?** Now learn *estar*’s forms and make the basic choice between Portuguese’s two verbs for “to be.”

|                          |                              |
|--------------------------|------------------------------|
| eu <b>estou</b>          | nós <b>estamos</b>           |
| tu <b>estás</b>          | ~~vós <b>estais</b> ~~       |
| ele/ela/você <b>está</b> | eles/elas/vocês <b>estão</b> |

Say **vocês estão** in ordinary speech. You may hear shortened *tou* and *tá*; recognise them, but write the full forms.

### Grammar Lens: What something is; how it is

**ser** = what something is **estar** = its location or the condition it is in

| <b>ser</b>                               | <b>estar</b>                                   |
|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Ele <b>é</b> médico. — He is a doctor.   | Ele <b>está</b> doente. — He is ill.           |
| <b>Sou</b> português. — I'm Portuguese.  | <b>Estou</b> em Lisboa. — I'm in Lisbon.       |
| A neve <b>é</b> branca. — Snow is white. | O café <b>está</b> frio. — The coffee is cold. |

Identity, origin, profession, and defining qualities use **ser**. Location, health, mood, weather, and resulting conditions use **estar**.

Do not reduce this to “permanent versus temporary”: **ele está morto**, “he is dead,” uses *estar*. Death is not temporary; it is a condition someone has ended up in.

### What you've built: A mnemonic, not the cause

*Ser* contains forms from Latin *sedēre*, “sit”; *estar* continues *stāre*, “stand.” Picture **ser** as seated in identity and **estar** as standing in a condition. The history is a memory aid, not the cause: *esse* supplied *ser*'s identity meaning, while *stāre* pulled toward place and resulting state.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “estou, estás, está, estamos, estão”]
- [YOU SAY: “Sou português; estou em Lisboa.”]
- [YOU SAY: “Ele é médico; ele está doente.”]

## Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which verb names identity? (**Ser**.) Which marks location or a resulting condition? (**Estar**.) How do you say “I’m in Lisbon”? (**Estou em Lisboa**.) Why does “he is dead” use *estar*? (It is a **resulting condition**, so permanence is not the real test.) Next: use the choice to change meaning.

## 16.4 é bonita / está bonita — a choice you can use

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] *Ser* and *estar* are not competing answers where one is always a mistake. With many adjectives, swapping the verb deliberately changes meaning.

| with <b>ser</b>                           | with <b>estar</b>                                  |
|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Ela <b>é</b> bonita. — She is beautiful.  | Ela <b>está</b> bonita. — She looks beautiful now. |
| A sopa <b>é</b> boa. — It is a good soup. | A sopa <b>está</b> boa. — This bowl tastes good.   |

**Ser** presents the quality as part of what the subject is. **Estar** presents the quality as the current condition or impression. Context, not a mechanical “permanent” rule, decides what you mean.

## The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Portuguese and Spanish maintain this full two-verb choice. Italian keeps *essere* and *stare* but lets them overlap differently; French has one *être* that absorbed old *stāre* pieces. German *sein* is a separate Germanic cousin.

| language             | broad result                       |
|----------------------|------------------------------------|
| Portuguese / Spanish | two verbs, chosen by meaning       |
| Italian              | two verbs with overlap             |
| French               | one fused verb                     |
| German               | one verb built from Germanic roots |

The Romance rows started with the same Latin material and reorganised it in three ways. That is why the Portuguese choice is systematic but not universal.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “Ela é bonita” — a quality]
- [YOU SAY: “Ela está bonita” — right now]
- [YOU SAY: “A sopa é boa; a sopa está boa.”]

[REPEAT x2] “Ser: what it is. Estar: the condition it is in.”

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What changes between *ela é bonita* and *ela está bonita*? (A defining quality versus a **current impression**.) Is *estar* automatically a mistake with *bonita*? (**No**; it says something different.) Which Romance languages keep the full two-verb choice? (**Portuguese and Spanish**.)

## Chapter 17

# Head and Hand

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

### 17.1 a cabeça — “the head”

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Learn one body word and one reading rule together.

**a cabeça** — the head, feminine

#### Sounds you’ll need

The **ç** is a **cedilla**. It marks a *c* pronounced **s** before *a*, *o*, or *u*, where plain *c* would normally be hard **k**. So *cabeça* ends roughly “-essa,” not “-eka.”

The mark began as a tiny **z** under the letter: medieval scribes used *ç* as shorthand for *cz*. Treat that as a recognition hook; this track has not yet asked you to write the mark by hand.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

**Cabeça** comes from Late Latin *capitia*, built from *caput*, “head.” Portuguese wore the word down in ordinary speech but kept the old root. A useful sentence is:

**Dói-me a cabeça.** — “My head hurts.” (European Portuguese)

In Brazilian Portuguese you may hear **Minha cabeça está doendo.**

Both begin with the same feminine noun **a cabeça**.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “a cabeça” — make **ç** an **s**]
- [YOU SAY: “Dói-me a cabeça.”]
- [YOU SAY: “cabeça ← caput”]

[REPEAT x2] “A cabeça — feminine; ç sounds s.”

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Say “the head.” (**A cabeça**.) What does the cedilla do? (Marks *c* as **s** before *a/o/u*.) What is the Latin root? (**Caput**.) Next: compare the head-words and find that root a second time in learned vocabulary.

## 17.2 cabeça / capital — one root, two arrivals

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s]

**Cabeça** kept Latin *caput*, “head.” Other languages used container words instead. That contrast makes the Portuguese survival visible.

| language   | “head”        | older picture             |
|------------|---------------|---------------------------|
| Portuguese | <b>cabeça</b> | Latin <i>caput</i> , head |
| Spanish    | <i>cabeza</i> | Latin <i>caput</i> , head |
| French     | <i>tête</i>   | Latin <i>testa</i> , pot  |
| Italian    | <i>testa</i>  | Latin <i>testa</i> , pot  |
| German     | <i>Kopf</i>   | Germanic “cup” word       |

French/Italian and German independently replaced “head” with a vessel. Iberian Romance kept *caput*. Portuguese still has **testa**, but narrowed it to “forehead” instead of the whole head.

### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The same *caput* later entered learned vocabulary again:

- **capital** — the head city or head sum;
- **capítulo** — a “little head” of a text;
- **capitão** — the head of a company.

Portuguese therefore holds a **doublet**: one word inherited through generations of speech (**cabeça**), another branch borrowed back from written Latin (**capital**, **capítulo**, **capitão**). One root can arrive twice and look different because each route changes it differently.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “cabeça — inherited”]
- [YOU SAY: “capital — re-borrowed”]
- [YOU SAY: “tête/testa: pot; Kopf: cup”]

[REPEAT x2] “Cabeça and capital — two routes from *caput*.”

### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which two languages kept *caput* as their everyday head-word? (**Portuguese and Spanish.**) What did French, Italian, and German use instead? (**Container words.**) Why do *cabeça* and *capital* look different? (One is **inherited**; one is **re-borrowed**.) Next: the hand and the disappearing *n*.

## 17.3 a mão — “the hand”

**Warm-up.** [PAUSE 2s] Two things in one short word: a sound change that shaped half of Portuguese, and a gender that is two thousand years old.

### You'll want to know: The word

a **mão** — the hand. **Feminine**. Plural: as **mãos**.

#### The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin *manus* → Portuguese *mão*. The **-n-** vanished.

That is not a one-off. Portuguese systematically **dropped n between vowels**, nasalising the vowel in front of it. What happened next depends on the word: the nasality **stayed** where the result was a nasal diphthong, and **faded again** where it left a plain vowel. The **til** (~) marks the ones that kept it.

| Latin        | Portuguese |                                                   |
|--------------|------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| <i>manus</i> | <b>mão</b> | hand — <b>nasality kept</b>                       |
| <i>lūna</i>  | <b>lua</b> | moon — nasality faded                             |
| <i>bona</i>  | <b>boa</b> | good (f.) — nasality faded                        |
| <i>pānis</i> | <b>pão</b> | bread — <b>kept</b> ;<br>Chapter 11 told this one |

Compare Spanish, which kept the **n** in all of them: *mano*, *luna*, *buena*, *pan*. This single change is a large part of why written Portuguese and Spanish look so similar and sound so different.

Say the pair aloud: *mano* ... *mão*. You can hear the *n* becoming the nasal.

#### Grammar Lens: Feminine, like Italian's

A **mão** is feminine — and so is Italian **la mano**, for the same reason. Latin *manus* belonged to the **fourth declension**, a class whose nouns ended in *-us* but could be feminine. The declension is long gone; the gender outlived it.

Portuguese is less startling about it than Italian, because *mão* doesn't end in a giveaway *-o*. But it is the same two-thousand-year-old fact underneath.

### Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]



- [YOU SAY: "a mão, as mãos"]
- [YOU SAY: the change — "manus ... mão"]
- [YOU SAY: the family — "lua, boa, pão — all lost an **n**"]
- [YOU SAY: the contrast — "Spanish *mano*, Portuguese *mão*"]

#### Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Say "the hand" and "the hands." (*A mão / as mãos*.) What happened to the *n* of *manus*? (It **dissolved between vowels**, leaving a nasal vowel — which the **til** marks.) Name two other words that did the same. (*Lua* ← *lūna*, *boa* ← *bona*, *pão* — Ch. 11.) Did they all keep the nasality? (**No** — *mão* and *pão* did; *lua* and *boa* lost it again.) What did Spanish do? (**Kept the *n*** in all — *mano*, *luna*, *pan*.) Why is *mão* feminine? (Latin *manus* was **fourth-declension feminine** — the same reason Italian says *la mano*.) Next: the rest of the body.